

Facilitator's Guide

to the

Twelve Steps

and

Twelve Traditions

A companion volume to the Plain Language Big Book facilitator's guide

For A.A. Book Study Meetings

About This Guide

This guide is built for facilitators of A.A. book study meetings working through the Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions, known in the Fellowship as the 12&12. It is a companion volume to the Plain Language Big Book facilitator's guide.

The guide covers 28 meetings. The Twelve Traditions are studied as twelve meetings, one per Tradition. The Twelve Steps are studied as sixteen meetings. Steps Four and Eleven are each split into two meetings, and Step Twelve is split into three meetings, because the source chapters cover more ground than a single 60-minute meeting can hold. Steps come first in this guide, then Traditions, because the two are not paired. They are companion bodies of work, not mirror images of each other.

How a Meeting Is Built

Each chapter in this guide uses the same nine-part structure. The order matches the order in which a facilitator typically uses the material.

Anchor Phrase. A short central line drawn from the chapter that the meeting can turn on. One primary anchor is offered, with three alternatives in case the primary does not fit a particular meeting, room, or season.

Background. A short historical and contextual note for the facilitator, drawn from A.A. source material. This sits at the top so the facilitator can read it before the meeting and carry the context into the room without sharing it directly.

Setting the Stage. A plain-language overview of what the chapter is teaching. Written so a newcomer can follow it. The facilitator can read all or part of this aloud at the start of the meeting, or simply use it to frame opening remarks.

Where We Begin. Seven opening-round questions designed to warm the room before the reading. Accessible to newcomers. Sets the stage without giving away the chapter's content.

Where We've Been (Experience). Fifteen questions on lived experience. What happened. What we did. What we saw in ourselves and in others.

Where We Stand (Strength). Fifteen questions on what the work has built. Evidence of the principle at work in a life today.

Where We're Going (Hope). Fifteen questions on what is becoming possible. Forward-looking without slipping into wishful thinking.

Closing Line. A brief, optional sentence the facilitator may read aloud to close the meeting.

Cross-Reference. A single line at the end where a natural connection exists between the Step or Tradition and another, offered only where the connection is real.

How to Use the Questions

Each round contains 15 questions. A typical 60-minute meeting will use only a handful of them. The questions are not a checklist. They are a deep well to draw from. Facilitators are encouraged to read through the full round before the meeting, choose three or four questions that fit the room and the season, and let the conversation breathe around those questions rather than rushing to cover more.

Questions are written to be answered out of experience, not opinion. They are not yes-or-no questions. They are not therapy probes. They are not surveys. Each one is built to make somebody pause before answering. If a question lands flat in your room, move on. If a question opens something up, stay with it.

The Anchor Phrase

Every chapter offers one anchor phrase, with three alternatives below it. The anchor is the line the meeting hangs on. Facilitators can read the anchor at the top of the meeting, return to it once or twice during the discussion, and close with it if it fits. The alternates are there in case the primary anchor does not match the tone of the room that day, or in case a facilitator wants to vary the anchor across multiple readings of the same chapter.

A Word on Tone

The questions in this guide stay aligned with A.A. language and the tone of the source material. They favor experience, strength, and hope. They examine behavior rather than theory. They ask how a principle shows up in a life, not how a member feels about a principle in the abstract. The Plain Language Big Book guide that came before this one set the same tone, and members familiar with that guide will find this one a natural continuation.

A Note on Sources

The primary text for this guide is *Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions*, by Bill Wilson, published in 1953. The Big Book and other A.A. literature appear as supporting references where useful. The Background notes draw on A.A. history, including Bill's correspondence, A.A. Comes of Age, and the recollections of early members.

Closing Note

This guide does not replace the chapter. It supports the chapter. The reading itself is the heart of the meeting. The questions are there to help members carry what they read into the room and out into their lives.

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Serenity Prayer

God, grant me the serenity
to accept the things I cannot change,
courage to change the things I can,
and wisdom to know the difference.

The Twelve Steps

1. We admitted we were powerless over alcohol, that our lives had become unmanageable.
2. Came to believe that a Power greater than ourselves could restore us to sanity.
3. Made a decision to turn our will and our lives over to the care of God as we understood Him.
4. Made a searching and fearless moral inventory of ourselves.
5. Admitted to God, to ourselves, and to another human being the exact nature of our wrongs.
6. Were entirely ready to have God remove all these defects of character.
7. Humbly asked Him to remove our shortcomings.
8. Made a list of all persons we had harmed, and became willing to make amends to them all.
9. Made direct amends to such people wherever possible, except when to do so would injure them or others.
10. Continued to take personal inventory and when we were wrong promptly admitted it.
11. Sought through prayer and meditation to improve our conscious contact with God as we understood Him, praying only for knowledge of His will for us and the power to carry that out.
12. Having had a spiritual awakening as the result of these Steps, we tried to carry this message to alcoholics, and to practice these principles in all our affairs.

The Twelve Traditions

1. Our common welfare should come first; personal recovery depends upon A.A. unity.
2. For our group purpose there is but one ultimate authority: a loving God as He may express Himself in our group conscience. Our leaders are but trusted servants; they do not govern.
3. The only requirement for A.A. membership is a desire to stop drinking.
4. Each group should be autonomous except in matters affecting other groups or A.A. as a whole.
5. Each group has but one primary purpose: to carry the message to the alcoholic who still suffers.
6. An A.A. group ought never endorse, finance, or lend the A.A. name to any related facility or outside enterprise, lest problems of money, property, and prestige divert us from our primary purpose.
7. Every A.A. group ought to be fully self-supporting, declining outside contributions.
8. Alcoholics Anonymous should remain forever nonprofessional, but our service centers may employ special workers.
9. A.A., as such, ought never be organized; but we may create service boards or committees directly responsible to those they serve.
10. Alcoholics Anonymous has no opinion on outside issues; hence the A.A. name ought never be drawn into public controversy.
11. Our public relations policy is based on attraction rather than promotion; we need always maintain personal anonymity at the level of press, radio, and films.
12. Anonymity is the spiritual foundation of all our Traditions, ever reminding us to place principles before personalities.

Just for Today

Just for today I will try to live through this day only, and not tackle all my problems at once. I can do something for twelve hours that would appall me if I felt that I had to keep it up for a lifetime.

Just for today I will be happy. This assumes that what Abraham Lincoln said is true, that “most folks are about as happy as they make up their minds to be.”

Just for today I will adjust myself to what is, and not try to adjust everything to my own desires. I will take my family, my business, and my luck as they come and fit myself to them.

Just for today I will try to strengthen my mind. I will study. I will learn something useful. I will not be a mental loafer. I will read something that requires effort, thought, and concentration.

Just for today I will exercise my soul in three ways: I will do somebody a good turn and not get found out. I will do at least two things I don't want to do, just for exercise. I will not show anyone that my feelings are hurt; they may be hurt, but today I will not show it.

Just for today I will be agreeable. I will look as well as I can, dress becomingly, speak softly, act courteously, be liberal with praise, criticize not at all, nor find fault with anything and not try to regulate nor improve anyone.

Just for today I will have a program. I may not follow it exactly, but I will have it. I will save myself from two pests: hurry and indecision.

Just for today I will have a quiet half hour all by myself and relax. In this half hour, sometimes I will think of God, so as to get a little more perspective into my life.

Just for today I will be unafraid. Especially I will not be afraid to enjoy what is beautiful, and to believe that as I give to the world, so the world will give to me.

Step One

"We admitted we were powerless over alcohol, that our lives had become unmanageable."

Anchor Phrase

Complete defeat was the firm bedrock upon which happy and purposeful lives may be built.

Alternatives, in case this one does not fit:

Only through utter defeat are we able to take our first steps toward liberation and strength.

We shall find no enduring strength until we first admit complete defeat.

We become as open-minded to conviction and as willing to listen as the dying can be.

Background

Bill Wilson wrote Step One for the 12&12 between 1952 and 1953 with roughly eighteen years of sobriety behind him. By that point he had watched countless members try to outsmart the First Step, including himself. The essay reflects two major shifts in A.A. since the Big Book was published in 1939. The pink-cloud optimism of the Big Book gives way to a heavier, more clinical tone. And the chapter explicitly addresses the newer class of high-bottom newcomers who arrived with their families, jobs, and even two cars still intact. Bill argues that the bottom must be raised so these members can hit it too. The harder tone of the chapter reflects Bill's mature view that surrender is not a one-time event at the start of sobriety but a daily practice the alcoholic returns to for life.

Setting the Stage

Step One is where everything in recovery starts. Bill Wilson opens with a question: who cares to admit complete defeat? Almost no one, he says. Every natural instinct cries out against the idea of personal powerlessness. And yet, Bill argues, this admission is the only foundation that can hold a sober life.

The chapter walks through the resistance most of us brought into the room. The belief that self-confidence would carry us through. The refusal to see what our drinking had become. The pride that kept us trying to fix ourselves on our own. Bill names the two forces that crushed us: the mental obsession that drove us back to drink, and the allergy of the body that ensured we would ultimately destroy ourselves in the process. The two together, he says, are too much for any unaided human will.

The chapter ends on a different note. Once we have hit bottom, Bill writes, we become as open-minded to conviction and as willing to listen as the dying can be. That willingness is what Step One opens up.

Where We Begin

Seven questions to set the room before reading.

1. When you hear the word powerless, what is the first thing that comes to mind?
2. What does the word defeat mean to you when you hear it in a recovery setting?
3. What did you believe about your drinking before you came into the rooms?
4. What is one thing you have tried to control that you have not been able to control?
5. What does it look like when a life is unmanageable?
6. When have you been forced to admit something you did not want to admit?
7. What brought you back to this room tonight?

Where We've Been

Fifteen questions on lived experience.

1. When did you first suspect that you could not drink like other people?
2. What did you try to do to control your drinking before you admitted you were powerless?
3. What did you tell yourself to keep drinking even when it was hurting you?
4. What did self-confidence get you when you tried to handle your drinking on your own?
5. What did unmanageability look like in your daily life when you were drinking?
6. Who or what did you blame for your drinking before you got honest about it?
7. What were you protecting when you would not admit you had a problem?
8. What did the obsession of the mind look like for you in your drinking?
9. What did the allergy of the body, the inability to stop once you started, look like for you?
10. When you tried to quit on your own, what happened?
11. What did your self-sufficiency cost you?
12. When did you first hear someone else describe powerlessness in a way you recognized?
13. Who in your life tried to tell you what you could not see about your own drinking?
14. What did your life look like the day you walked into your first meeting?
15. What did it feel like to say out loud, for the first time, that you were an alcoholic?

Where We Stand

Fifteen questions on what the work has built.

1. What does it mean to you today to say you are powerless over alcohol?
2. How has admitting powerlessness given you any kind of freedom?
3. Where in your life are you still trying to control what you cannot control?
4. What does manageability look like in your life today, even on a hard day?
5. What does it mean to you today to say "I am an alcoholic" out loud?
6. When you hear a newcomer share their story, what do you recognize in it?
7. Where have you found strength in admitting weakness?
8. How do you tell the difference today between what you can change and what you cannot?
9. What does it look like in your life when you forget you are powerless?
10. What does it mean to have a foundation under your sobriety?
11. Where have you seen the bedrock of Step One hold under pressure?
12. What is one area of your life today where Step One is still doing its work in you?
13. How has Step One changed the way you talk to yourself when things are hard?
14. What is one thing you no longer try to do alone?
15. What is one way Step One is still saving your life today?

Where We're Going

Fifteen questions on what is becoming possible.

1. What do you hope to understand about Step One that you do not understand yet?
2. What does a deeper acceptance of powerlessness look like for you going forward?
3. Where in your life right now is Step One asking you to go deeper?
4. What is one small honest admission you could make this week?
5. What is one thing you want to stop trying to manage on your own?
6. Who in your life might be on the edge of their own Step One?
7. What might your life look like a year from now if you keep practicing Step One?
8. What hope does it give you to know that defeat can be the bedrock of something new?
9. What does it mean to you that this Step is something you keep coming back to?
10. What is one thing you want to remember the next time you feel like you are in control?
11. What would surrender look like for you this week?

12. What would it look like to be as open-minded and as willing to listen as Bill describes?
13. What has Step One opened up for you that you did not expect?
14. What is one thing you want to carry with you out of this meeting tonight?
15. What does it look like to walk in true powerlessness and true freedom at the same time?

Closing Line

We came here because we could not do this alone. We stay because we no longer have to.

Cross-Reference

Members studying Tradition One alongside this Step may notice a shared theme: neither the individual nor the group survives alone.

Step Two

"Came to believe that a Power greater than ourselves could restore us to sanity."

Anchor Phrase

True humility and an open mind can lead us to faith.

Alternatives, in case this one does not fit:

Step Two is the rallying point for all of us.

All you really need is a truly open mind.

Whether agnostic, atheist, or former believer, we can stand together on this Step.

Background

Bill Wilson wrote the 12&12 essay on Step Two in 1953 to address what he had come to see as the most common stumbling point in A.A. By that time he had spent nearly two decades counseling newcomers who got stuck here. The structure of the chapter walks methodically through six types of resistance Bill had personally seen most often: the militant atheist, the wanderer from faith, the intellectually self-sufficient, the religious cynic, the defiant alcoholic, and the devout member who is still drinking.

Setting the Stage

Step Two arrives just when the newcomer is least ready for it. We have just admitted we are powerless. We have just admitted our lives are unmanageable. Now Bill Wilson says the only thing that can restore us is a Power greater than ourselves. For many of us, this is the hardest sentence in the program.

This chapter is written for the resistant. Bill walks through the militant atheist, the disappointed believer, the intellectually self-sufficient, the religious cynic, the defiant, and the devout member who is still drinking, one type at a time. He tells each of them they belong here. He says the only requirement is an open mind.

The chapter is gentle in places and pointed in others. The point Bill keeps returning to is that sanity, the soundness of mind we cannot give ourselves, is something we can receive if we are willing to stop arguing and start listening.

Where We Begin

Seven questions to set the room before reading.

1. When you hear the phrase “a Power greater than ourselves,” what is the first thing that comes to mind?
2. What does the word sanity mean to you?
3. What is one thing you have come to believe that you once doubted?
4. When have you had to keep an open mind about something you did not want to consider?
5. What did you believe about God or a higher power before you came into the rooms?
6. What does it mean to be restored to something?
7. When you walked into your first meeting, what were you hoping might turn out to be true?

Where We've Been

Fifteen questions on lived experience.

1. What did you believe about a higher power before you got sober?
2. What were you resistant to about Step Two when you first read it?
3. What did you tell yourself about people who believed in something greater than themselves?
4. When did you first see someone in A.A. who had something you wanted?
5. What is one thing you did while drinking that you can now see as plain insanity?
6. What did self-sufficiency cost you in your drinking?
7. Who in your life saw your insanity before you could see it?
8. What did defiance look like in your drinking days?
9. What did you blame God or your higher power for before you got here?
10. When did you first hear someone in A.A. talk about a higher power in a way that did not push you away?
11. What did it take for you to stop arguing and start listening?
12. What did the group do for you in your early days that you could not do for yourself?
13. What is one prayer you said while drinking that did not work?
14. When did you first start to believe that A.A. could actually keep you sober?
15. What did it feel like the first time you said the word “we” and meant it?

Where We Stand

Fifteen questions on what the work has built.

1. What does it mean to you today to say you believe in a Power greater than yourself?
2. What does sanity look like in your life right now?
3. Where in your life are you still defying a Power greater than yourself?
4. What does your Higher Power look like to you today?
5. How has your understanding of Step Two changed since the first time you read it?
6. What does it look like when you are operating from an open mind?
7. What is one piece of evidence in your life that something has restored you to sanity?
8. How do you tell, day to day, the difference between sanity and insanity in your own thinking?
9. What does humility look like for you today?
10. Who in the rooms has shown you what faith that works looks like?
11. What does it mean to you to be part of the rallying point Bill describes?
12. What is one thing in your life right now that you are trying to handle on your own that belongs to a Higher Power?
13. Where in your group life is Step Two doing its work in you?
14. What does it cost you when you forget that you needed restoring?
15. How does the group keep restoring your sanity in ways you cannot do for yourself?

Where We're Going

Fifteen questions on what is becoming possible.

1. What does a deeper relationship with a Power greater than yourself look like for you going forward?
2. Where in your life is your sanity still being restored?
3. What is one piece of defiance you want to lay down?
4. What would it look like to keep an open mind in an area where you have always closed it?
5. Who in your life might be on the edge of their own Step Two?
6. What does it look like to live as someone who has been restored to sanity?
7. What is one prayer you want to learn how to pray?
8. What is one thing you want to stop arguing about?
9. What does it mean to you that Step Two is a rallying point and not a finish line?
10. Where in your life are you still telling your Higher Power what His will ought to be?
11. What would it look like to receive grace this week instead of demanding it?

12. What do you hope to come to believe that you cannot fully believe yet?
13. What does it look like to live with humility and intellect at the same time?
14. What is one thing you want to carry out of this meeting tonight?
15. What would it mean to keep walking this Step for the rest of your life?

Closing Line

We came in defiance. We stay because something larger has begun to restore us.

Cross-Reference

Members studying Tradition Two alongside this Step may notice a shared theme: authority comes from a Power outside the self.

Step Three

“Made a decision to turn our will and our lives over to the care of God as we understood Him.”

Anchor Phrase

The more we become willing to depend upon a Higher Power, the more independent we actually are.

Alternatives, in case this one does not fit:

There is only one key, and it is called willingness.

Dependence, as A.A. practices it, is really a means of gaining true independence of the spirit.

It is when we try to make our will conform with God's that we begin to use it rightly.

Background

Bill Wilson wrote the 12&12 essay on Step Three in 1953 to address a misunderstanding he had observed in A.A. Members had begun to treat Step Three as a vague spiritual sentiment rather than a concrete decision requiring sustained action. The essay builds a careful case for the kind of dependence that, rightly placed, becomes the source of independence and strength. Bill offers an unexpected piece of evidence: A.A. members serving overseas during World War II had fewer alcoholic lapses than members who remained home. The chapter closes with the Serenity Prayer offered as a practical Step Three application in moments of emotional disturbance or indecision.

Setting the Stage

Step Three asks us to do something we have not been asked to do before. Steps One and Two required only acceptance. We admitted we were powerless, and we came to believe a Power greater than ourselves could restore us. Step Three calls for action. Bill Wilson writes that Step Three is the opening of a door that is still closed and locked. The key is willingness.

The hard work of the chapter is dismantling the idea that depending on a Higher Power makes us less. Bill names this fear directly, putting it in the voice of the resisting alcoholic: “I’ll look like the hole in the doughnut.” He answers it with a paradox. The more we become willing to depend on a Higher Power, the more independent we actually are. He gives the example of electricity, of a polio patient in an iron lung, of A.A. members who served in World War II. Dependence rightly placed is not weakness. It is the source of real strength.

The chapter ends practically. We make our beginning where we can: pause, ask for quiet, and pray the Serenity Prayer. Step Three is not a feeling we wait for. It is a decision we make again and again, in small moments, throughout a day.

Where We Begin

Seven questions to set the room before reading.

1. When you hear the word willingness, what is the first thing that comes to mind?
2. What does it mean to turn your will and your life over to something?
3. What is one decision you have made that changed the direction of your life?
4. What does the word dependence mean to you?
5. When have you had to ask for help that you did not want to ask for?
6. What does it mean to have a key to a door you cannot open on your own?
7. What is one area of your life today where you are still trying to do it alone?

Where We've Been

Fifteen questions on lived experience.

1. What did self-will look like in your drinking days?
2. What did you try to bombard with willpower that did not yield to it?
3. When you got sober, what was the first thing you turned over to A.A. that you had been trying to handle yourself?
4. Who was the first person in A.A. you began to truly depend on?
5. What did it cost you to maintain your independence when you were drinking?
6. What did the juggernaut of self-sufficiency look like in your life?
7. When did you first understand that even sober, your life was still unmanageable?
8. What problem in early sobriety would not yield to your own effort?
9. What did you tell yourself about needing other people before you got here?
10. When did you first hear someone in A.A. say "I cannot do this alone" in a way you understood?
11. Who were you still bitter toward when you got sober?
12. What is one thing your sponsor or a trusted member asked you to turn over in early sobriety?
13. What was the first prayer you said in sobriety that you actually meant?
14. When did you first try the Serenity Prayer and mean it?

15. What did you discover the first time you let go of something you had been gripping?

Where We Stand

Fifteen questions on what the work has built.

1. What does turning your will and your life over to a Higher Power look like in your day today?
2. What is one area of your life where you are practicing Step Three regularly?
3. What does your willingness look like today compared to when you first got sober?
4. Where in your life today are you still trying to play God?
5. Where has dependence on your Higher Power made you more free?
6. When self-will slams the door shut, how do you find the key again?
7. What does the Serenity Prayer mean to you today?
8. Where have you seen the paradox at work in your life that depending makes you stronger, not weaker?
9. What does it look like when you bring your will into agreement with your Higher Power's?
10. What is one situation today where you have to choose between your way and turning it over?
11. How do you tell the difference between turning something over and abandoning it?
12. What does it look like to make this decision again in a moment of emotional disturbance?
13. Where in your group life is Step Three doing its work in you?
14. What has Step Three given you that willpower alone never did?
15. What is one thing you have stopped bombarding with your own will?

Where We're Going

Fifteen questions on what is becoming possible.

1. What does a deeper practice of Step Three look like for you going forward?
2. Where in your life is Step Three asking you to make a new decision?
3. What is one thing you want to stop carrying alone?
4. What would it look like to begin each day with a Step Three decision?
5. Where in your life are you still treating dependence as weakness?
6. Who in your life might be on the edge of their own Step Three?
7. What is one piece of self-sufficiency you are ready to lay down?

8. What does it mean to you that Step Three is a decision you make again and again?
9. What is one prayer you want to learn to pray in moments of emotional disturbance?
10. What would it look like to bring your will into agreement with your Higher Power's this week?
11. Where would you like to feel the paradox of dependence as freedom more deeply?
12. What is one decision you can make today that you have been putting off?
13. What does it look like to live as someone whose chief source of strength is dependence?
14. What is one thing you want to carry out of this meeting tonight?
15. What does it mean to you to turn the key of willingness every day for the rest of your life?

Closing Line

We came in clutching our own will. We stay because we have learned to turn it over.

Cross-Reference

Members studying Tradition Three alongside this Step may notice a shared theme: willingness, not perfection, is what gets us through the door.

Step Four, Part 1

“Made a searching and fearless moral inventory of ourselves.”

Part 1 of 2. This meeting covers the case for inventory and the instincts framework, pages 42 to 48.

Anchor Phrase

Nearly every serious emotional problem can be seen as a case of misdirected instinct.

Alternatives, in case this one does not fit:

Our great natural assets, the instincts, have turned into physical and mental liabilities.

Whenever a human being becomes a battleground for the instincts, there can be no peace.

Step Four is our vigorous and painstaking effort to discover what these liabilities in each of us have been, and are.

Background

Bill Wilson wrote Step Four for the 12&12 in 1953 as a long, deliberate essay because he had seen the Step misunderstood more than any other. He wanted to give the newcomer a framework, not just an instruction. The instinct theory he introduces here reflects his reading of psychiatric thinking of the day, particularly the work of Carl Jung and Dr. Harry Tiebout, medical director of Blythewood Sanitarium in Greenwich, Connecticut, who had been close to A.A. since the late 1930s. The chapter is one continuous essay in the 12&12; this guide divides it into two meetings. The first half lays out the theory of misdirected instincts and the two personality types most resistant to inventory: the depressive and the power-driver. The second half introduces the Seven Deadly Sins, fear, and the practical work of writing the inventory.

Setting the Stage

Bill Wilson opens Step Four with a surprising claim. The instincts that get us into so much trouble are not bad. They are God-given. The drive for security, for sex, for companionship, for a place in the world is necessary and right. The problem is not the instincts themselves. The problem is what happens when they exceed their proper functions and begin to rule our lives.

This is the heart of the chapter. Nearly every serious emotional problem, Bill writes, can be seen as a case of misdirected instinct. Our great natural assets have turned into liabilities. The drinking did not start in a vacuum. It started in instincts that had gone out of joint, and it kept going because the instincts kept demanding more than life could give.

Bill spends much of the first half of the chapter on two personalities who resist inventory. The depressive sinks into guilt and self-loathing and calls it humility, when it is really pride in reverse. The self-righteous newcomer points at other people, says they need the inventory, and clutches at the excuse that conditions are to blame. Both responses, Bill says, are forms of self-justification. Both keep the door to Step Four locked. The sponsor's approach is different for each. The depressive needs comfort and balance, a reminder that his case is not strange and that he has assets alongside his liabilities. The self-righteous newcomer needs help finding a chink in the wall the ego has built, through which the light of reason can shine.

Where We Begin

Seven questions to set the room before reading.

1. When you hear the word inventory, what is the first thing that comes to mind?
2. What does the word instinct mean to you?
3. What is one drive in you that is good in the right place and dangerous out of place?
4. When have you watched someone use guilt as a substitute for honesty?
5. When have you watched someone blame others for what was really theirs?
6. What does it mean to be fearless about something painful?
7. What did you expect Step Four would feel like before you read it?

Where We've Been

Fifteen questions on lived experience.

1. What did your drive for security look like in your drinking days?
2. What did your drive for sex or attention look like in your drinking days?
3. What did your drive for a place in the world look like in your drinking days?
4. When did one of your natural desires first start to rule you?
5. What is one instinct in you that, when it went out of joint, hurt the people around you?
6. What were you trying to drown when you drank?
7. What were you trying to make possible when you drank?
8. What did self-justification sound like coming out of your mouth in your drinking days?
9. What alibi for drinking did you tell yourself the longest?
10. Did you arrive at A.A. more like the depressive Bill describes, more like the self-righteous newcomer, or some mix of both?
11. What did wallowing in guilt and calling it humility look like in your life?
12. What did pointing the finger at other people sound like in your thinking?

13. Who was the first person to gently challenge your version of who was to blame?
14. What did your first sponsor say about their own defects that helped you look at yours?
15. What did you discover the first time you tried to write an inventory?

Where We Stand

Fifteen questions on what the work has built.

1. What does it mean to you today to call your instincts assets that can become liabilities?
2. Which of your instincts most often pushes past its proper function in your life today?
3. What does misdirected instinct look like in your behavior now?
4. Where in your life today are you still being driven by a drive for security?
5. Where in your life today are you still being driven by a drive for sex or attention?
6. Where in your life today are you still being driven by a drive for prestige or a place at the table?
7. How do you tell the difference today between a healthy desire and one that is out of joint?
8. What does self-justification sound like in your thinking today?
9. What does pride in reverse look like in you when it shows up?
10. What does power-driving look like in you when it shows up?
11. What does it look like in your life when blame creeps back into your speech and thought?
12. How do you quiet the disturbance in yourself when you are convinced someone else caused it?
13. How does the group help you see what you cannot see on your own?
14. What is one asset of yours that you can now name alongside your liabilities?
15. What does perspective on yourself look like today that it did not look like before?

Where We're Going

Fifteen questions on what is becoming possible.

1. What does a deeper practice of self-examination look like for you going forward?
2. Which of your instincts is asking for closer attention right now?
3. What is one alibi you are ready to stop telling yourself?
4. What is one resentment you have been calling the “right kind” that you are ready to reexamine?

5. Where in your life are you still trying to change conditions instead of changing yourself?
6. What would it look like to drop the word blame from your speech and thought this week?
7. What is one place where pride in reverse is still keeping you from honest inventory?
8. What is one place where pride forward is still keeping you from honest inventory?
9. Who in your life might be on the edge of their own Step Four?
10. What would it look like to be fearless rather than fearful about what you find in yourself?
11. What is one chink in the wall of your own ego that the light is starting to shine through?
12. What does it look like to gain in humility this week, in Bill's sense of getting perspective on yourself?
13. What asset of yours are you ready to start using more deliberately?
14. What is one thing you want to carry out of this meeting tonight?
15. What does it look like to keep watching your instincts for the rest of your life?

Closing Line

We came in blaming. We stay because we have learned to look in the mirror without flinching.

Cross-Reference

Members studying Tradition Four alongside this Step may notice a shared theme: freedom requires self-examination, both for the person and for the group.

Step Four, Part 2

“Made a searching and fearless moral inventory of ourselves.”

Part 2 of 2. This meeting covers the Seven Deadly Sins, fear, and the practical inventory work, pages 48 to 54.

Anchor Phrase

Pride says, “You need not pass this way,” and Fear says, “You dare not look!”

Alternatives, in case this one does not fit:

These fears are the termites that ceaselessly devour the foundations of whatever sort of life we try to build.

Thoroughness ought to be the watchword when taking inventory.

A brand-new kind of confidence is born, and the sense of relief at finally facing ourselves is indescribable.

Background

The second half of Step Four moves from theory into practice. Bill Wilson uses the Seven Deadly Sins of the Western moral tradition as a shared vocabulary because, in his words, members would otherwise argue over what to call their defects. He places pride at the head of the list deliberately. Pride is the breeder of self-justification, and self-justification is what keeps the inventory from getting written. Bill then introduces fear as a soul-sickness in its own right, the engine that drives the other defects. The chapter closes with a long set of specific inventory questions on sex, financial security, emotional security, and relationships. Bill ends with a practical instruction: write out the questions and answers. The writing is the first tangible evidence of willingness.

Setting the Stage

The first half of Step Four named the problem. The second half names the defects and shows us how to begin. Bill Wilson uses the Seven Deadly Sins as a working vocabulary: pride, greed, lust, anger, gluttony, envy, and sloth. Pride heads the list because pride leads to self-justification, and self-justification is the wall that keeps inventory at bay.

Underneath all the defects, Bill writes, is fear. Fear that our instincts will not be satisfied. Fear that we will not have enough, will not be enough, will not be loved enough. That fear drives the coveting, the lust, the anger, the envy, the greed, the laziness. Fear is the termite eating the

foundation of whatever we try to build. When A.A. suggests a fearless moral inventory, pride and fear both stand up at once. Pride says you do not need to do this. Fear says you do not dare. Bill calls both of them bogeymen. Walk through them and a brand-new kind of confidence is born.

The chapter ends practically. Bill walks the newcomer through inventory questions on sex, on financial security, on emotional security, on relationships. He notes the two patterns most of us fall into with other people: we dominate, or we lean. Both block the partnership we were made for. And he closes with a concrete instruction. Write it out. Questions and answers, on paper. The writing is the first tangible evidence of willingness to move forward.

Where We Begin

Seven questions to set the room before reading.

1. When you hear the phrase Seven Deadly Sins, what comes to mind?
2. Which of the seven, pride, greed, lust, anger, gluttony, envy, or sloth, do you find easiest to talk about?
3. Which one do you find hardest to talk about?
4. What does fear have to do with the way you behave when you are not at your best?
5. When have you watched pride and fear team up to keep you from looking at something?
6. What does it mean to write something down rather than just think about it?
7. What did you expect would happen the first time you wrote an inventory?

Where We've Been

Fifteen questions on lived experience.

1. Which of the Seven Deadly Sins did the most damage in your drinking days?
2. What did pride sound like in your thinking when you were drinking?
3. What did greed look like in your behavior when you were drinking?
4. What did lust drive you to do that you would not otherwise have done?
5. What did anger cost you in your drinking?
6. What did envy poison in you when it took hold?
7. What did sloth look like in your life, in work or in relationships?
8. What were the fears that kept you reaching for the next drink?
9. What were you afraid would happen if you ever stopped long enough to look at yourself?
10. What did Pride say to you the first time you tried to look at your defects?
11. What did Fear say to you the first time you tried to look at your defects?

12. What did your sex inventory turn up that you had been hiding even from yourself?
13. What did your financial inventory turn up that surprised you?
14. What did your relationships inventory turn up about whether you dominated or leaned?
15. What changed in you the first time you wrote it down rather than just thought it?

Where We Stand

Fifteen questions on what the work has built.

1. Which of the Seven Deadly Sins is still asking for your attention today?
2. What does pride look like in you now, when you are tired or threatened?
3. What does anger look like in you now, when something does not go your way?
4. What does envy look like in you now, when someone else gets what you wanted?
5. What does sloth look like in you now, in the parts of your life you are avoiding?
6. What fear is still driving the most behavior in you today?
7. What does it look like in your life when fear acts as the termite Bill describes?
8. Where in your life today are you still trying to dominate the people around you?
9. Where in your life today are you still leaning too hard on someone who cannot carry it?
10. Where in your life are you still hiding a defect under a thick layer of self-justification?
11. How do you tell, now, when pride is talking and pretending to be reason?
12. How do you tell, now, when fear is talking and pretending to be common sense?
13. What does a current inventory look like for you in this season of your sobriety?
14. What does the relief Bill describes feel like in your life now?
15. Where has facing yourself given you a kind of confidence you did not have before?

Where We're Going

Fifteen questions on what is becoming possible.

1. Which of your defects is asking for closer attention right now?
2. What is one fear you are ready to name and write down this week?
3. What is one piece of self-justification you are ready to lay down?
4. What would thoroughness look like in your inventory going forward?
5. What does it look like to be a partner rather than a dominator in your relationships?
6. What does it look like to be a partner rather than a leaner in your relationships?
7. Who in your life might be on the edge of their own Step Four?

8. What is one question Bill asked in the chapter that you are not done answering?
9. What would it look like to write out the questions and answers this week, even briefly?
10. What is one pattern around money or work that you are ready to look at honestly?
11. What is one pattern around sex or attention that you are ready to look at honestly?
12. What is one relationship you are ready to inventory with new eyes?
13. What does it look like to live as someone who keeps a current inventory for life?
14. What is one thing you want to carry out of this meeting tonight?
15. What does it mean to you that Step Four is the beginning of a lifetime practice and not a one-time task?

Closing Line

We came in afraid to look. We stay because the looking has set us free.

Cross-Reference

Members studying Step Five alongside Step Four may notice a shared theme: what we write down in private must eventually be spoken aloud.

Step Five

“Admitted to God, to ourselves, and to another human being the exact nature of our wrongs.”

Anchor Phrase

The dammed-up emotions of years break out of their confinement, and miraculously vanish as soon as they are exposed.

Alternatives, in case this one does not fit:

Until we had talked with complete candor of our conflicts, and had listened to someone else do the same thing, we still didn't belong.

Step Five was the beginning of true kinship with man and God.

Without a fearless admission of our defects to another human being we could not stay sober.

Background

Bill Wilson wrote Step Five for the 12&12 in 1953 with eighteen years of sobriety and roughly a decade of close observation of the Step in practice. He was especially attentive to the members who had skimmed it. By 1953 he had watched A.A. old timers, sober for years, suffer through irritability, anxiety, remorse, and depression that traced back to a held-back Fifth Step. The chapter draws explicitly on both the ancient religious tradition of confession and the modern psychiatric understanding that every human being needs an outside listener. Bill is careful in this chapter to offer flexibility about who that listener should be, naming sponsors, clergy, doctors, and even complete strangers as appropriate choices.

Setting the Stage

Step Five takes what we wrote down in Step Four and asks us to speak it out loud to another person. Bill Wilson is direct about how hard this is. All twelve Steps deflate the ego, but few are harder than this one. The temptation is to skim it. Give a general admission that we were sometimes bad actors. Throw in a few dramatic stories everybody already knows. Hold back the ones that really burn.

Bill writes that this skimming is not just unwise. It is perilous. The held-back Fifth Step is the thing that keeps members irritable, anxious, depressed, and sometimes drinking again, even years into sobriety. The relief, he writes, never comes from confessing the sins of other people. Everybody has to confess his own.

The chapter then names what Step Five gives us. It ends the isolation we have carried since long before our drinking got bad. It opens the door to forgiveness, both receiving it and giving it. It is the beginning of real humility, which Bill defines as a clear recognition of what and who we really are. And often, it is the moment when members who had been agnostic or atheistic first feel the presence of God. The chapter ends at a resting place: at one with God and man, ready for the Steps that follow.

Where We Begin

Seven questions to set the room before reading.

1. When you hear the word confession, what is the first thing that comes to mind?
2. What does it cost to say something out loud rather than just think it?
3. What is one thing you have carried alone that you wish you had not?
4. What does belonging look like to you?
5. When have you been on the receiving end of someone else's honesty in a way that helped you?
6. What does it mean to be forgiven?
7. What did you expect Step Five would feel like before you took it?

Where We've Been

Fifteen questions on lived experience.

1. What did the prospect of telling another person everything feel like before you did it?
2. What were you most afraid the other person would think of you?
3. What memories did you tell yourself ought to go to the grave with you?
4. What did the isolation Bill describes look like in your life, even before the drinking got bad?
5. When did you first sense the mysterious barrier between you and other people that Bill names?
6. Who was the first person you sat down with for your Fifth Step?
7. How did you choose them?
8. What did you almost leave out that you ended up saying?
9. What did the listener say or do that made it easier to keep going?
10. What did your listener share about themselves that placed you more at ease?
11. What did the relief feel like as you kept talking?
12. When did you first feel the dammed-up emotions break out of confinement?

13. When did you first feel forgiven?
14. When did you first feel able to forgive someone else?
15. What did you walk out of your Fifth Step understanding about yourself that you did not understand walking in?

Where We Stand

Fifteen questions on what the work has built.

1. What does it mean to you today to have spoken aloud what you once swore would die with you?
2. What does kinship with man and God look like in your life now?
3. Where in your life today do you still need to talk to somebody about what is bothering you?
4. What does it look like in your life when you start carrying a load alone again?
5. How do you tell the difference today between a passing trouble and something that needs a Fifth Step conversation?
6. What does humility look like in you now, in Bill's sense of seeing what and who you really are?
7. Where has self-delusion shown up in you even since taking your Fifth Step?
8. What does it look like when you start accusing other people of the defects you have been concealing in yourself?
9. Where in your life today are you tempted to deal with God alone and skip the human being?
10. What has talking to another person about your defects taught you that praying alone did not?
11. Who in your life now functions as the trusted listener Bill describes?
12. What does it look like when you give forgiveness rather than receive it?
13. How does your home group keep you honest in ways you cannot keep yourself honest?
14. What does the resting place at the end of Step Five feel like to you now?
15. What is one piece of guilt or shame that no longer has any power over you because you spoke it aloud?

Where We're Going

Fifteen questions on what is becoming possible.

1. What is one thing you have been carrying that you are ready to speak aloud this week?

2. Who in your life might be the right listener for that?
3. What does a deeper practice of Step Five look like for you going forward?
4. What does it look like to keep a current Fifth Step in this season of your sobriety?
5. What is one piece of self-delusion you suspect you are still holding?
6. What is one resentment you have been blaming on someone else that may belong to you?
7. Who in your life might be on the edge of their own Step Five?
8. What would it look like to be the trustworthy listener for someone else?
9. What is one forgiveness you are ready to receive?
10. What is one forgiveness you are ready to give?
11. What does it look like to live as someone who has nothing to hide?
12. Where in your life do you still need willpower of the kind Bill describes to walk across the room and start the conversation?
13. What would it mean for you to feel the presence of God in the way Bill describes at the end of the chapter?
14. What is one thing you want to carry out of this meeting tonight?
15. What does it look like to keep practicing Step Five for the rest of your life?

Closing Line

We came in carrying secrets. We stay because we have learned what speaking them aloud can do.

Cross-Reference

Members studying Tradition Five alongside this Step may notice a shared theme: the alcoholic and the group both find their purpose in honest exchange with another human being.

Step Six

"Were entirely ready to have God remove all these defects of character."

Anchor Phrase

What we must recognize now is that we exult in some of our defects. We really love them.

Alternatives, in case this one does not fit:

This is the Step that separates the men from the boys.

The moment we say, "No, never!" our minds close against the grace of God.

Step Six is A.A.'s way of stating the best possible attitude one can take in order to make a beginning on this lifetime job.

Background

Bill Wilson wrote Step Six for the 12&12 in 1953 as one of the shorter essays, but it carries a sharp argument. By the early 1950s Bill had observed that members tended to coast through Step Six because the action it asks for is interior rather than visible. He uses the chapter to push members past the obvious defects, the ones nobody wants to keep anyway, into the milder defects we secretly enjoy. The "men from the boys" line comes from Father Edward Dowling, the Jesuit priest who became one of Bill's closest spiritual advisers after a 1940 meeting in New York. Bill considered Dowling one of A.A.'s greatest friends, and quoted him in the opening line of this chapter as a way of signaling how much weight the Step carries.

Setting the Stage

Step Six asks one question. Are we entirely ready to have God remove our defects of character? Bill Wilson opens with Father Edward Dowling's line that this is the Step that separates the men from the boys. The challenge is not the obvious defects. Almost nobody wants to be greedy enough to be called a thief, or angry enough to murder, or lustful enough to rape. We agree to let those go without much spiritual effort because keeping them would cost us too much anyway.

The work of Step Six is in the milder defects we love. Bill names them one by one. The little superiority we feel over the next person. Greed dressed up as ambition. Lust hidden inside what we call romance. Anger called righteousness. Gossip called concern. Gluttony called taking our comfort. Envy called wishing. Sloth called retirement, or procrastination. Bill writes that nearly anyone could submit a list of such defects, and few of us would seriously think of giving them up until they have caused us excessive misery.

The chapter is realistic about what readiness means. In an absolute sense, practically nobody has it. There is always a sticking point. The difference between Step Six working and Step Six failing is the difference between “I cannot give this up yet” and “I will never give this up.” The first leaves the door open. The second slams it shut. Step Six does not ask for perfection. It asks for willingness to walk toward it, however haltingly.

Where We Begin

Seven questions to set the room before reading.

1. When you hear the word ready, what does it mean to you?
2. What is one thing in your life you have agreed to give up easily?
3. What is one thing in your life you have not been ready to give up?
4. What does it mean to be entirely ready as opposed to mostly ready?
5. When have you said “not yet” about something you knew you would eventually have to face?
6. When have you said “never” about something that turned out to be exactly what you needed to give up?
7. What did you expect Step Six would feel like before you read it?

Where We've Been

Fifteen questions on lived experience.

1. Which of your obvious defects were you happy to let go of when you got sober?
2. Which of your defects did you not realize you had been enjoying until you read this chapter?
3. What did the superiority Bill describes look like in your drinking days?
4. What did greed dressed up as ambition look like in your life?
5. What did anger dressed up as righteousness look like in your life?
6. What did gossip dressed up as concern look like in your speech?
7. What did envy dressed up as wishing look like in your thinking?
8. What did sloth dressed up as comfort look like in your habits?
9. When did you first hear someone in A.A. describe a defect you secretly enjoyed?
10. What is one defect you tried to keep when you were new in sobriety?
11. What did “I will never give this up” sound like in your head about a particular defect?
12. What did your sponsor or a trusted member say about a defect you were not ready to release?

13. What did it take to move from “never” to “not yet” about something?
14. What was the first defect you let God remove that you had truly loved?
15. What did your life look like after that defect was gone?

Where We Stand

Fifteen questions on what the work has built.

1. Which of your defects are you most ready to have removed today?
2. Which of your defects are you least ready to have removed today?
3. What is one defect you are still calling by a nicer name?
4. What does superiority over the next person look like in you now when it shows up?
5. What does self-righteous anger look like in you now when it shows up?
6. What does gossip look like in you now when you are tired or stressed?
7. What does envy look like in you now in a quieter form?
8. What does procrastination look like in you as a current defect?
9. Where in your life today are you saying “not yet”?
10. Where in your life today are you saying “never”?
11. What does the difference feel like in you between those two answers?
12. How do you tell when self-interest is doing the work of spiritual progress in you?
13. What is one defect you have grown out of since you got sober that you did not expect to grow out of?
14. How does your home group help you see the defects you would rather not see?
15. Where in your life right now is Step Six asking you to make a beginning?

Where We're Going

Fifteen questions on what is becoming possible.

1. What is one defect you are ready to become entirely ready about this week?
2. What is one “never” you are ready to soften to “not yet”?
3. What does it look like to walk toward perfection without expecting to arrive?
4. What is one defect you have been pardoning longer than you should have?
5. What does open-mindedness about a defect look like for you going forward?
6. Where in your life are you ready to abandon a limited objective and move toward God's will?

7. Who in your life might be on the edge of their own Step Six?
8. What does it look like in your life when you let the grace of God in on a defect?
9. What is one milder defect you are willing to stop enjoying?
10. What does it look like to be a person who keeps coming back to Step Six over and over?
11. What would it mean to aim at the very best you know or can learn?
12. What is one sticking point in you that may be ready to move?
13. What does it look like to live as someone whose mind is not closed to the grace of God on any defect?
14. What is one thing you want to carry out of this meeting tonight?
15. What does it mean to you to keep practicing Step Six for the rest of your life?

Closing Line

We came in attached to defects we loved. We stay because we have learned to set them down, one at a time.

Cross-Reference

Members studying Step Seven alongside Step Six may notice a shared theme: readiness comes first, then the humble asking.

Step Seven

"Humbly asked Him to remove our shortcomings."

Anchor Phrase

The chief activator of our defects has been self-centered fear.

Alternatives, in case this one does not fit:

Humility, as a word and as an ideal, has a very bad time of it in our world.

A great turning point in our lives came when we sought for humility as something we really wanted, rather than as something we must have.

Pain had been the price of admission into a new life.

Background

Bill Wilson wrote Step Seven in 1953 as essentially an essay on humility. He believed it was the most misunderstood word in the program. The Step itself is one sentence, but the chapter is one of the longest in the 12&12 because Bill wanted to redefine the word from the ground up. He pushes back on a cultural moment in postwar America that he saw as drunk on its own progress, where intelligence and labor were thought to be enough to shape human destiny. The phrase "Of myself I am nothing, the Father doeth the works" is quoted from the Gospel of John, a passage Bill returned to often in his own spiritual reading. He uses it here to mark the shift from humility as something forced on us by suffering to humility as something we choose because we have come to want it.

Setting the Stage

Step Seven is one sentence long. The chapter is much longer than that because Bill Wilson believes humility is the foundation principle of every Step, and he wants to spend real time on what it is and what it is not. He notes that the word itself is disliked. Many people, he writes, have not even a nodding acquaintance with humility as a way of life. The world we live in talks endlessly about pride in achievement and rarely about humility as a virtue.

The chapter traces a movement. At first, Bill writes, we accept humility only because we have to. Powerlessness over alcohol forces a first humbling, and we breathe a sigh of relief thinking we will never have to go through that again. Then we realize the defects that drove our drinking are still with us, and that humility is required to face them too. We do it grudgingly. We still do not particularly like humility. We recognize it only as a necessary aid to survival.

Then something shifts. As the worst defects start to leave us, we begin to feel real peace of mind for the first time. We start to see that pain has been the price of admission into a new life, and that humility has been the healer of pain. We stop running. We begin to want humility, not just tolerate it. Bill names self-centered fear as the chief activator of our defects, fear that we will lose what we have or fail to get what we want. Step Seven is the change of attitude that lets us move out from ourselves, toward other people, toward God. It is the willingness to bring to every shortcoming the same humility that first kept us sober.

Where We Begin

Seven questions to set the room before reading.

1. When you hear the word humility, what is the first thing that comes to mind?
2. What did the word mean to you before you came into A.A.?
3. What does it mean to ask for something humbly as opposed to demanding it?
4. What is one thing you have been forced to learn that you did not want to learn?
5. What does peace of mind look like to you?
6. When have you been afraid of losing something you already had?
7. When have you been afraid of not getting something you wanted?

Where We've Been

Fifteen questions on lived experience.

1. What did you think humility meant before you came into A.A.?
2. What did your pride sound like in your drinking days?
3. Where did you place self-reliance first in your drinking life?
4. What did chasing security, prestige, or romance look like in your drinking?
5. What did it cost you to confuse the ends with the means?
6. When was the first time you experienced humility as something more than groveling despair?
7. What was the first humbling that opened the door to your sobriety?
8. What did "Well, thank God that's over" sound like in you, before you realized the work had only just begun?
9. What was your first reaction to the idea that you would have to keep practicing humility past Step One?
10. Who in the rooms first showed you what humility actually looks like?
11. When did you first see failure or misery transformed by humility in someone else's life?

12. What did self-centered fear look like in your behavior when you first got sober?
13. What were you most afraid of losing in early sobriety?
14. What were you most afraid of failing to get in early sobriety?
15. When did you first stop reaching for the bottle to deal with pain and start letting the pain teach you something?

Where We Stand

Fifteen questions on what the work has built.

1. What does humility mean to you today?
2. What does self-centered fear look like in you now when it shows up?
3. What is one shortcoming you can trace back to the fear of losing what you have?
4. What is one shortcoming you can trace back to the fear of not getting what you want?
5. Where in your life today are you treating your Higher Power like a pinch hitter rather than the source?
6. What does it look like in your day when you place self-reliance first?
7. How do you tell the difference today between a demand and a simple request?
8. What does peace of mind look like in your life now?
9. Where have you watched humility heal pain in your own life?
10. What is one ego-puncturing experience you can now see as a gift?
11. What does it mean to you to want humility rather than just need it?
12. Where in your life is character-building winning out over comfort?
13. Where in your life is comfort still winning out over character-building?
14. How does your home group keep teaching you humility in ways you cannot teach yourself?
15. What does it look like when you humbly ask, rather than demand, that a shortcoming be removed?

Where We're Going

Fifteen questions on what is becoming possible.

1. What does a deeper humility look like for you going forward?
2. What is one fear-driven demand you are ready to bring down to a request?
3. Where in your life are you ready to stop running from pain?
4. What is one shortcoming you are ready to humbly ask to have removed this week?

5. What does it look like to seek humility voluntarily rather than wait to be bludgeoned into it?
6. Where in your life are you still trying to play God?
7. What would it look like to make honesty, tolerance, and love the daily basis of your living?
8. Who in your life might be on the edge of their own Step Seven?
9. What is one demand on yourself you are ready to lay down?
10. What is one demand on another person you are ready to lay down?
11. What is one demand on God you are ready to lay down?
12. What would it mean to live by character-building as something desirable in itself?
13. What does it look like to live as someone who has stopped fearing pain quite so much?
14. What is one thing you want to carry out of this meeting tonight?
15. What does it mean to you to keep practicing Step Seven for the rest of your life?

Closing Line

We came in demanding. We stay because we have learned how to humbly ask.

Cross-Reference

Members studying Tradition Seven alongside this Step may notice a shared theme: self-support and humility belong together, in the life of the alcoholic and in the life of the group.

Step Eight

“Made a list of all persons we had harmed, and became willing to make amends to them all.”

Anchor Phrase

It is the beginning of the end of isolation from our fellows and from God.

Alternatives, in case this one does not fit:

Defective relations with other human beings have nearly always been the immediate cause of our woes, including our alcoholism.

Harm is the result of instincts in collision, which cause physical, mental, emotional, or spiritual damage to people.

If we are now about to ask forgiveness for ourselves, why shouldn't we start out by forgiving them, one and all?

Background

Bill Wilson wrote Step Eight for the 12&12 in 1953 as the first of two chapters dedicated to personal relations. By that point Bill had watched countless members try to skip from Step Five directly to Step Nine without preparing the list or doing the inner work of becoming willing. He uses Step Eight to slow them down. The chapter introduces a definition of harm that goes well beyond physical or financial damage. Bill draws it from his framework of instincts in collision, the same framework he developed in Step Four. The chapter is also where Bill makes one of his most uncomfortable arguments: that part of becoming willing to make amends is becoming willing to forgive the people who harmed us, one and all, before we approach them.

Setting the Stage

Steps Eight and Nine are about personal relations. Bill Wilson lays out the work in three movements. First, look backward and find where we have been at fault. Next, repair the damage. Third, with our newfound knowledge of ourselves, build the best possible relations with every human being we know. It is a very large order. Bill writes that it is a task we may perform with increasing skill but never really finish.

The chapter walks through three obstacles. The first is forgiveness. The moment we ponder a broken relationship, our emotions go on the defensive. We seize on what the other person did to us as a way to minimize what we did to them. Bill stops us short. We are not the only people bedeviled by sick emotions. Our drinking often made other people's defects worse. If we are about to ask forgiveness for ourselves, we should start by giving it.

The second obstacle is fear and pride. The list looks doable until we remember that the list is the first step toward a face-to-face conversation. Then we start asking why bygones cannot be bygones. The third obstacle is the opposite. Some of us still claim we never hurt anybody but ourselves. Bill calls this the end result of purposeful forgetting. The chapter then redefines harm. It is the result of instincts in collision causing physical, mental, emotional, or spiritual damage. The miserly father, the irritable spouse, the dominating boss, the self-pitying friend, all of them are doing harm even when no one is bleeding. The list, Bill writes, will be longer than we think. And making it is the beginning of the end of isolation from our fellows and from God.

Where We Begin

Seven questions to set the room before reading.

1. When you hear the word amends, what is the first thing that comes to mind?
2. What does it mean to make a list of people you have harmed?
3. What kinds of harm are easier to recognize than others?
4. What does forgiveness have to do with amends?
5. When have you been more focused on what someone did to you than on what you did to them?
6. Who is the first person who comes to mind when you think about Step Eight?
7. What did you expect this Step would feel like before you read it?

Where We've Been

Fifteen questions on lived experience.

1. What did you tell yourself about the people you had hurt before you sat down to write your list?
2. What did your first list look like when you actually started writing it?
3. Who appeared on your list that you had been forgetting about?
4. Who appeared on your list that you had been minimizing?
5. Who appeared on your list that you had been blaming instead?
6. What did you discover when you tried to forgive the people whose names ended up on your list?
7. Where did your drinking make somebody else's defects worse?
8. What is one harm you did that was not financial or physical, but emotional or spiritual?
9. What did the miserly, callous, or irritable version of you look like at home?
10. What did the dominating or controlling version of you look like with the people closest to you?

11. What did the self-pitying version of you inflict on the people around you?
12. When did you first realize you had been hurting people you thought you were not hurting?
13. Who in your life had been telling you the truth about your harm long before you could hear it?
14. What was the hardest name to put on your list?
15. What changed in you between the first draft of your list and the final one?

Where We Stand

Fifteen questions on what the work has built.

1. What does your understanding of harm look like today compared to when you first read this Step?
2. What does it look like in your life now when instincts collide and somebody gets hurt?
3. Where in your life today are you still focused on what others did to you rather than what you did to them?
4. What does forgiving the people on your list mean to you today?
5. Where in your life are you still purposefully forgetting?
6. How do you tell, now, when you are making someone else's bad behavior an excuse to skip your own inventory?
7. What does it look like in your life when you take a personality trait into the workplace that does harm there?
8. Where in your closest relationships are you still doing one of the subtler harms Bill names?
9. What is one current relationship where Step Eight is still doing its work in you?
10. What does the calm, objective view of yourself and others look like in your life now?
11. How does your home group help you see harms you cannot see on your own?
12. What does it mean to you today that this Step is the beginning of the end of isolation?
13. What does living in peace, partnership, and brotherhood look like for you right now?
14. What is one piece of damage from your drinking days that has actually been repaired?
15. What does it look like to keep a current Step Eight list in this season of your sobriety?

Where We're Going

Fifteen questions on what is becoming possible.

1. What does a deeper practice of Step Eight look like for you going forward?

2. Whose name belongs on your list this year that was not there before?
3. Who in your life are you ready to forgive in order to free yourself to make amends?
4. What is one purposeful forgetting you are ready to stop?
5. What is one subtle harm you are ready to take seriously?
6. Who in your life might be on the edge of their own Step Eight?
7. What would it look like to be a person who keeps a clean list as a way of life?
8. What is one extreme judgment of yourself you are ready to let go of?
9. What is one extreme judgment of someone else you are ready to let go of?
10. Where in your life are you ready to look at instincts in collision and see your part?
11. What is one face-to-face conversation you are becoming willing to have?
12. What is one relationship you are ready to rebuild, even before any amends conversation happens?
13. What does it look like to live as someone who has dropped the word blame from speech and thought?
14. What is one thing you want to carry out of this meeting tonight?
15. What does it mean to you to keep practicing Step Eight for the rest of your life?

Closing Line

We came in keeping score. We stay because we have learned how to make a list and become willing.

Cross-Reference

Members studying Step Nine alongside Step Eight may notice a shared theme: willingness is what we build before action becomes possible.

Step Nine

“Made direct amends to such people wherever possible, except when to do so would injure them or others.”

Anchor Phrase

Good judgment, a careful sense of timing, courage, and prudence: these are the qualities we shall need when we take Step Nine.

Alternatives, in case this one does not fit:

The readiness to take the full consequences of our past acts, and to take responsibility for the well-being of others at the same time, is the very spirit of Step Nine.

We cannot buy our own peace of mind at the expense of others.

Let's not talk prudence while practicing evasion.

Background

Bill Wilson wrote Step Nine for the 12&12 in 1953 as a chapter about discernment. By the early 1950s he had watched both kinds of failure with this Step. Some members tried to rush through amends with reckless honesty that did more damage than the original harm. Others used the “would injure them or others” clause as an indefinite escape hatch. Bill wrote the chapter to hold both errors in tension. He names four qualities at the top of the essay: good judgment, a careful sense of timing, courage, and prudence. The chapter is structured around the practical question of how to sort amends into categories, when to act fast, when to defer, and when partial disclosure is the right move. The chapter's closing line warns against the most common evasion: delaying because we are afraid and calling it prudence.

Setting the Stage

Step Nine asks for four things at once. Good judgment. A careful sense of timing. Courage. Prudence. Bill Wilson names them up front because all four are required and any one of them, used alone, can produce its own kind of damage.

The chapter sorts amends into several classes. There are people we can approach as soon as we are reasonably confident in our sobriety. There are people to whom we can make only partial restitution, because complete disclosure would do more harm than good. There are people with whom action ought to be deferred. And there are people we will never be able to reach directly at all.

Bill walks through the family first, then the workplace. With the family, the work usually begins the day we walk in the door from our first meeting and tell them we are going to try. With the workplace, more discretion is usually needed. We wait until we are on the A.A. beam. Then we go to those most affected, explain what A.A. is, admit the damage, and pay what we owe.

Then comes the warning. After the early relief of the easier amends, we will be tempted to rest. We will manufacture plausible reasons to skip the harder ones. Bill writes one of the sharpest sentences in the entire 12&12 here: let us not talk prudence while practicing evasion. He closes by naming the one true exception to disclosure, the case where it would seriously harm the other person or someone else. The most common example he gives is unloading a detailed account of an affair on an unsuspecting spouse. The principle, he writes, is that we do not lighten our own burden by recklessly making the crosses of others heavier. We carry the full consequences of our past acts and we carry responsibility for the well-being of others. That double weight is the spirit of Step Nine.

Where We Begin

Seven questions to set the room before reading.

1. When you hear the word amends, how is it different from the word apology?
2. What does good judgment mean to you?
3. What does a careful sense of timing mean to you?
4. When have you confused prudence with avoidance?
5. When have you confused courage with recklessness?
6. Who is the first person who comes to mind when you think about direct amends?
7. What did you expect Step Nine would feel like before you read it?

Where We've Been

Fifteen questions on lived experience.

1. Who was the first person you sat down with to make a direct amends?
2. What did the conversation look like before you began, and what did it look like after?
3. What did you discover about the other person that you did not expect?
4. What did you discover about yourself during that conversation?
5. Where did you have to wait before making an amends, and what did the waiting teach you?
6. Where did you have to act faster than you wanted to?
7. Who was on your list that you could never make direct contact with, and what did you do instead?

8. Where did you have to settle for partial amends because a full disclosure would have done more harm than good?
9. When did you talk prudence while really practicing evasion?
10. What was the hardest amends you have made?
11. What was the surprise amends, the one you thought would be hard and was not?
12. Who responded with grace that you did not deserve?
13. Who responded with coolness or rejection, and how did you handle it?
14. What did the early relief of an easier amends tempt you to skip?
15. What did making the harder amends give you that the easier ones did not?

Where We Stand

Fifteen questions on what the work has built.

1. What does it mean to you today to make direct amends rather than just say you are sorry?
2. What does good judgment look like in your amends work now?
3. What does a careful sense of timing look like in your amends work now?
4. Where in your life today are you tempted to argue or press your point when the response is not what you wanted?
5. Where in your life today are you tempted to get an insatiable appetite for approval after an amends has gone well?
6. What is one amends still outstanding on your list?
7. What is one amends you have already made that needed to be made again at a deeper level?
8. How do you tell the difference today between true prudence and the prudence excuse?
9. Where in your life are you living amends now, in your behavior rather than in a conversation?
10. What does it look like to keep amends current rather than letting them pile up?
11. How does your home group keep you honest about the amends you are still avoiding?
12. What does it look like in your life when you carry the full consequences of a past act?
13. What does it look like in your life when you carry responsibility for someone else's well-being at the same time?
14. What does making amends teach you about restraint of tongue and pen?
15. Where has a Step Nine conversation changed a relationship more than you thought possible?

Where We're Going

Fifteen questions on what is becoming possible.

1. What is one amends you are becoming ready to make in this season of your sobriety?
2. Who in your life is asking, in some form, for a different kind of amends than you have made so far?
3. What does deeper amends work look like for you going forward?
4. What is one prudence excuse you are ready to retire?
5. What is one fear that has been stopping you from making an amends?
6. Who in your life might be on the edge of their own Step Nine?
7. What does it look like to be a person whose word can be trusted because of how amends are made?
8. What is one living amends you want to deepen?
9. What does courage look like for you in the next amends you have to make?
10. What does it look like to refuse to lighten your own burden by making someone else's heavier?
11. What is one amends conversation you want to walk into with all four qualities Bill names?
12. What is one relationship you are ready to rebuild beyond the original amends?
13. What does it look like to live as someone who has cleaned away the debris of the past?
14. What is one thing you want to carry out of this meeting tonight?
15. What does it mean to you to keep practicing Step Nine for the rest of your life?

Closing Line

We came in carrying debts we could not pay. We stay because we have learned how to make them right.

Cross-Reference

Members studying Step Ten alongside Step Nine may notice a shared theme: amends made today keep tomorrow's slate clean.

Step Ten

“Continued to take personal inventory and when we were wrong promptly admitted it.”

Anchor Phrase

It is a spiritual axiom that every time we are disturbed, no matter what the cause, there is something wrong with us.

Alternatives, in case this one does not fit:

Nothing pays off like restraint of tongue and pen.

We shall look for progress, not for perfection.

Pain was the touchstone of all spiritual progress.

Background

Bill Wilson wrote Step Ten for the 12&12 in 1953 as the chapter that turns the program from a sequence into a way of life. By that point Bill had observed A.A. members long enough to see two failure modes around inventory. Some members did one Step Four early and never came back to it. Others did inventory constantly but morbidly, picking at themselves without ever resolving anything. Bill wrote Step Ten to correct both. He introduces three forms of inventory, the spot-check, the day's-end review, and the periodic housecleaning, and frames them as practical tools rather than spiritual obligations. The chapter contains one of the most quoted sentences in all of A.A. literature: “It is a spiritual axiom that every time we are disturbed, no matter what the cause, there is something wrong with us.” Bill used this line as a permanent corrective to the alcoholic's habit of locating the problem outside himself.

Setting the Stage

Step Ten is where the work of the first nine Steps becomes a daily practice. Bill Wilson opens the chapter with the acid test: can we stay sober, keep in emotional balance, and live to good purpose under all conditions? He notes that a drunk's hangover is obvious. There is another kind of hangover, the emotional one, that follows yesterday's excesses of anger, fear, jealousy, and pride. Step Ten is how we keep ourselves clear of both.

Bill names three forms of inventory. The spot-check, taken whenever we find ourselves getting tangled up. The day's-end review, where we tally what we did well and where we fell short. The occasional retreat or housecleaning, alone or with a sponsor. The point of all three is the same. Self-examination becomes a regular habit. We learn to admit what we find and to correct what is wrong.

The hard teaching of the chapter is the spiritual axiom: every time we are disturbed, no matter what the cause, there is something wrong with us. Bill does not soften this. Even justified anger, he writes, is dangerous for the alcoholic. The chief discipline of Step Ten is self-restraint, what Bill calls restraint of tongue and pen. One unkind tirade or one willful snap judgment can ruin a relationship for a day or a year. The other discipline is honesty about motives. We will catch ourselves giving constructive criticism that is really a power play, or asking for sympathy when we say we feel bad, or punishing someone we tell ourselves we are teaching. The chapter closes on a quieter note. The evening inventory is not always done in red ink. Most of our hours are filled with constructive things. Honest regret for harms done, gratitude for blessings, and willingness to try for better tomorrow are the permanent assets we seek.

Where We Begin

Seven questions to set the room before reading.

1. When you hear the phrase daily inventory, what is the first thing that comes to mind?
2. What does an emotional hangover feel like?
3. What does restraint of tongue and pen mean to you?
4. When have you been certain your anger was justified and later realized it was not?
5. What does it mean to be disturbed, in the sense Bill uses the word?
6. When have you given constructive criticism that was actually something else?
7. What did you expect Step Ten would feel like before you read it?

Where We've Been

Fifteen questions on lived experience.

1. What did your emotional hangovers look like in your drinking days?
2. What did your justified anger look like, and what did it cost you?
3. What did a well-nursed grudge do to you when you were drinking?
4. What did big-shot-ism look like in you when things were going well?
5. What did self-pity look like in you when things were going badly?
6. When you first heard the line that every time we are disturbed there is something wrong with us, how did you react?
7. What did your first attempts at a daily inventory look like?
8. What did you discover the first time you took a spot-check inventory in the middle of a disturbance?
9. What is one situation in early sobriety where restraint of tongue would have saved you a lot of trouble?

10. What is one situation in early sobriety where you spoke or wrote in haste and regretted it?
11. When did you first catch yourself hiding a bad motive underneath a good one?
12. What did rationalization sound like in your thinking back then?
13. Who in the rooms taught you the practice of evening review?
14. What did you discover the first time you wrote down what you did well as part of your inventory, not just what you did wrong?
15. When did Step Ten first start to feel like a way of life rather than a chore?

Where We Stand

Fifteen questions on what the work has built.

1. What does your daily inventory practice look like today?
2. What does a spot-check inventory look like for you in the middle of a tangled-up moment?
3. What does your day's-end review look like, if you do one?
4. Where in your life today are you tempted by justified anger?
5. Where in your life today are you tempted by big-shot-ism?
6. Where in your life today are you tempted by sulking or silent scorn, what Bill calls the booby trap baited with pride?
7. How do you tell, now, when you are constructively criticizing and when you are pulling someone down?
8. How do you tell, now, when you are sharing how you feel and when you are mainly asking for sympathy?
9. What does restraint of tongue and pen look like in your life right now?
10. Where has Step Ten saved you from speaking or writing something you would have regretted?
11. What does it look like when you promptly admit you are wrong?
12. What does it look like when you do not promptly admit it?
13. How does your home group help you keep a current inventory?
14. What does the credit side of your daily ledger look like in this season of your sobriety?
15. What does honest regret, genuine gratitude, and willingness to try for better tomorrow look like as a daily practice for you?

Where We're Going

Fifteen questions on what is becoming possible.

1. What does a deeper Step Ten practice look like for you going forward?
2. What is one form of inventory you want to add to your day or week?
3. Where in your life are you still locating the problem outside yourself?
4. What is one piece of justified anger you are ready to set down?
5. What is one self-righteousness you suspect is hiding under a good motive?
6. Who in your life might be on the edge of their own Step Ten?
7. What would it look like to live with restraint of tongue and pen as a default rather than an effort?
8. Where in your life is courtesy, kindness, justice, and love asking to replace something else?
9. What is one disturbance you keep falling into that Step Ten can help you address?
10. What would it look like to keep an evening review that includes what you did well as honestly as it includes what you got wrong?
11. What is one motive you want to look at more carefully this week?
12. What does it mean to you to keep looking for progress and not for perfection?
13. What does it look like to live as someone who admits a mistake the moment they make it?
14. What is one thing you want to carry out of this meeting tonight?
15. What does it mean to you to keep practicing Step Ten for the rest of your life?

Closing Line

We came in carrying yesterday. We stay because we have learned how to settle each day before it ends.

Cross-Reference

Members studying Step Eleven alongside Step Ten may notice a shared theme: a daily practice of self-examination prepares the ground for a daily practice of prayer and meditation.

Step Eleven, Part 1

“Sought through prayer and meditation to improve our conscious contact with God as we understood Him, praying only for knowledge of His will for us and the power to carry that out.”

Part 1 of 2. This meeting covers the case for prayer and meditation and the St. Francis prayer as a meditation exercise, pages 96 to 101.

Anchor Phrase

Almost the only scoffers at prayer are those who never tried it enough.

Alternatives, in case this one does not fit:

Prayer and meditation are our principal means of conscious contact with God.

Meditation is our step out into the sun.

It is by self-forgetting that one finds.

Background

Bill Wilson wrote Step Eleven for the 12&12 in 1953 as the chapter where the spiritual practice of A.A. comes into its fullest form. By that point Bill had been working closely for over a decade with Father Edward Dowling, the Jesuit priest he considered one of his most important spiritual advisers, and had been reading widely in the contemplative traditions. He chose the prayer commonly called the Peace Prayer of St. Francis as the meditation exercise for this chapter, even though he knew it was not strictly an A.A. prayer. Bill picked it because it could be received by members of any faith or none, and because it expressed in a single passage the spiritual aim of the entire program. The author of this prayer, by the way, is anonymous; it first appeared in a French religious magazine in 1912 and was only later attributed to Francis of Assisi. Bill calls the author a saint, and the line opens the door for any A.A. member, however skeptical, to receive what the prayer offers.

Setting the Stage

Step Eleven is where prayer and meditation become a daily practice. Bill Wilson opens by naming the obstacle most A.A. members face here. We are active people. We enjoy dealing with the realities of life, often for the first time, and we are busy trying to help the next alcoholic. So we tend to slight serious prayer and meditation as something not really necessary, or as a skill that belongs to clergymen, or as something we do not believe in at all.

Bill is patient with the resistance. He acknowledges the agnostic logic that points to the suffering of the world and concludes there cannot be a God. He acknowledges the position that there might be a first cause but no God who knows or cares about human beings. He says he understands these positions because he held them himself. And then he names the way out. Almost the only scoffers at prayer, he writes, are those who never tried it enough. The members who once held back are the ones who experimented, got unexpected results, and were sold on it. He compares prayer and meditation to air, food, and sunlight. The soul, like the body, can fail its purpose for lack of nourishment.

Bill then introduces a practice. He takes the prayer commonly attributed to St. Francis of Assisi, the Peace Prayer, and walks the reader through it as a meditation. He invites the newcomer to read it slowly, drop resistance, and rest with the thoughts of someone who knows. He suggests using the sunlit beach as an image, breathing the spiritual atmosphere of the words, looking out toward the horizon. Then he walks through the prayer's inner essence. The man who wrote it wanted to become a channel. He wanted to bring love, forgiveness, harmony, truth, faith, hope, light, and joy. And he hoped to find these by self-forgetting, by giving comfort rather than receiving it, by understanding rather than being understood, by forgiving rather than being forgiven. This, Bill writes, is meditation. Or at least a beginning of it.

Where We Begin

Seven questions to set the room before reading.

1. When you hear the word prayer, what is the first thing that comes to mind?
2. When you hear the word meditation, what is the first thing that comes to mind?
3. What did you believe about prayer before you came into A.A.?
4. When have you been a scoffer about something you had never actually tried?
5. What does it mean to be a channel?
6. What does self-forgetting mean to you?
7. What did you expect Step Eleven would feel like before you read it?

Where We've Been

Fifteen questions on lived experience.

1. What did your prayer life look like, if you had one, before you got sober?
2. What did your image of God look like back then, and where did it come from?
3. What logic did you use to argue yourself out of prayer when you were drinking?
4. What did the suffering in the world look like to you as evidence about God?
5. When did you first try a prayer and mean it?

6. What unexpected result did you get the first time you experimented seriously with prayer?
7. Who in the rooms first showed you what a prayer life looked like in practice?
8. What prayer did you pray in early sobriety that you keep coming back to?
9. What did your first attempts at meditation look like?
10. What resistance did you bring to the St. Francis prayer the first time you read it?
11. What line of that prayer landed hardest the first time you sat with it?
12. What did the channel image open up for you, if it did?
13. When did self-forgetting first start to make sense to you as a way of being?
14. What did you discover the first time you preferred to give comfort rather than receive it?
15. What did you discover the first time you preferred to understand rather than be understood?

Where We Stand

Fifteen questions on what the work has built.

1. What does your prayer life look like today?
2. What does your meditation practice look like today, if you have one?
3. Where in your week do you make space for the sunlit beach Bill describes?
4. What does it mean to you today to be a channel?
5. Which line of the St. Francis prayer is doing the most work in you now?
6. What does self-forgetting look like in your life right now?
7. Where in your life are you currently giving comfort rather than asking for it?
8. Where in your life are you currently seeking to understand rather than to be understood?
9. Where in your life are you currently choosing to forgive rather than be forgiven?
10. When you skip prayer or meditation, how do you notice it in yourself?
11. What does nourishment of the soul, in the way Bill describes, feel like to you?
12. How does your home group support your prayer and meditation life?
13. What logic do you still occasionally reach for to argue yourself out of prayer?
14. What unexpected results have you received since you started actually practicing this Step?
15. How has prayer and meditation changed the rest of your day?

Where We're Going

Fifteen questions on what is becoming possible.

1. What does a deeper prayer and meditation practice look like for you going forward?
2. What is one prayer you want to learn how to pray?
3. What is one classic prayer you want to start sitting with the way Bill suggests sitting with the St. Francis prayer?
4. Where in your life are you ready to stop scoffing and start trying?
5. Which line of the St. Francis prayer are you ready to live this week?
6. What would it look like for you to become a channel of peace in one specific relationship?
7. Where in your life is hatred asking to be met with love?
8. Where in your life is despair asking to be met with hope?
9. Where in your life is darkness asking to be met with light?
10. Where in your life is sadness asking to be met with joy?
11. What does self-forgetting look like for you in this season of your sobriety?
12. Who in your life might be on the edge of their own Step Eleven?
13. What would it look like to live as someone whose first instinct is prayer rather than panic?
14. What is one thing you want to carry out of this meeting tonight?
15. What does it mean to you to keep practicing prayer for the rest of your life?

Closing Line

We came in scoffing. We stay because we finally tried it enough.

Cross-Reference

Members studying Step Twelve, Part 1 alongside Step Eleven, Part 1 may notice a shared theme: the spiritual awakening promised at the end of the Steps begins in the quiet practice of prayer.

Step Eleven, Part 2

“Sought through prayer and meditation to improve our conscious contact with God as we understood Him, praying only for knowledge of His will for us and the power to carry that out.”

Part 2 of 2. This meeting covers prayer as petition, the hazards of asking for specific guidance, and the rewards of conscious contact, pages 101 to 105.

Anchor Phrase

We discover that we do receive guidance for our lives to just about the extent that we stop making demands upon God to give it to us on order and on our terms.

Alternatives, in case this one does not fit:

Perhaps one of the greatest rewards of meditation and prayer is the sense of belonging that comes to us.

Thy will, not mine, be done.

We no longer live in a completely hostile world.

Background

Bill Wilson wrote the second half of Step Eleven with a particular concern in mind. He had spent the late 1930s in the Oxford Group, a movement that placed enormous weight on a practice it called guidance: sitting in silence and writing down what one believed God was telling one to do. Bill had watched well-meaning people use this practice to confirm their own preferences and then act on them with great certainty. By the time Bill's New York group separated from the Oxford Group in 1937 (the Akron group followed in 1939), Bill had concluded that the practice was dangerous when divorced from humility. He carries that conviction into this chapter. He affirms prayer as a real and powerful practice, but he is careful to warn against treating prayer as a way to get God to confirm what we already wanted. The line that prayer's guidance comes to the extent that we stop demanding it is one of the most carefully worded sentences in the entire 12&12.

Setting the Stage

Bill Wilson opens the second half of Step Eleven by asking what prayer is. Prayer, he writes, is the raising of the heart and mind to God. In its broadest sense it includes meditation. In its more

common sense it is petition. We open the channel as best we can, and we try to ask for the right things, of which we and others are in the greatest need.

The chapter offers a simple morning practice. We think of the hours to come, of our work, of any problem that might arise. Our immediate temptation will be to ask for specific solutions to specific problems and for the ability to help other people the way we have already decided they should be helped. That, Bill says, is asking God to do it our way. Instead we add a qualification to every request: if it be Thy will. We ask simply that God place in us the best understanding of His will that we can have for the day, and the grace to carry it out. As the day goes on, when we have to make decisions or face hard moments, we pause and renew the simple request: Thy will, not mine, be done.

Bill then names two hazards. The first is mistaking unconscious rationalization for divine guidance. A.A. members, with the best of intentions, can ask God for explicit answers to problems large and small, and then mistake their own wishful thinking for the reply. The person who lives this way, Bill writes, becomes a particularly disconcerting individual, forcing his own will into every situation under the comfortable assurance that he is acting under God's direction. The second hazard is presuming to know God's will for other people. We pray that someone be cured, relieved, fixed in a specific way. The prayer is good, but the presumption beneath it is conceit. The corrective in both cases is the same: pray that God's will, whatever it is, be done.

The chapter closes on a quieter note. The actual fruits of prayer, Bill writes, are beyond question. Strength not ordinarily our own. Wisdom beyond our usual capability. Peace of mind that holds in hard circumstances. New lessons learned from every season of grief. Even in seasons when we cannot pray, or when rebellion makes us refuse to pray, we should not think too ill of ourselves. We resume when we can. And perhaps one of the greatest rewards, Bill writes, is the sense of belonging that comes to us. We no longer live in a completely hostile world.

Where We Begin

Seven questions to set the room before reading.

1. When you hear the phrase Thy will, not mine, be done, what is the first thing that comes to mind?
2. What does it mean to ask for guidance as opposed to asking for an outcome?
3. When have you confused what you wanted with what was right?
4. When have you been certain you knew what was best for somebody else?
5. What does conscious contact mean to you?
6. What does it mean to belong?
7. What did you expect this part of Step Eleven would feel like before you read it?

Where We've Been

Fifteen questions on lived experience.

1. What was the first prayer of petition you said in sobriety and meant?
2. What did your prayers sound like before you learned to add "if it be Thy will"?
3. What did your prayers sound like when you were really telling God how to do His job?
4. When did you first start practicing a morning prayer?
5. When did you first start practicing "Thy will, not mine, be done" in the middle of a hard moment?
6. What did you discover when you stopped asking for specific answers and started asking for the next right thing?
7. When did you mistake your own rationalization for God's guidance?
8. What did acting on that mistaken guidance cost you?
9. When did you presume to know what God's will was for someone else?
10. What happened when you prayed for someone in the way you thought they should be fixed?
11. What was a season of grief or suffering that taught you something you could not have learned otherwise?
12. When have you been so rebellious you simply would not pray?
13. What did you do during the seasons when prayer felt impossible?
14. When did the sense of belonging Bill describes first land on you?
15. What did your first taste of peace of mind in the middle of trouble feel like?

Where We Stand

Fifteen questions on what the work has built.

1. What does your morning prayer practice look like today?
2. What does your prayer practice in the middle of a hard moment look like today?
3. Where in your life are you still asking God to do it your way?
4. Where in your life are you still asking God to fix someone else the way you think they should be fixed?
5. How do you tell the difference today between guidance and rationalization?
6. What phrase or short prayer do you repeat when the channel is choked up with anger or fear?

7. What is one specific situation where Thy will, not mine, be done is doing real work in you right now?
8. Where in your life have you received strength not ordinarily your own?
9. Where in your life have you received wisdom beyond your usual capability?
10. Where in your life have you received peace of mind that surprised you?
11. What is one season of grief that turned out to teach you something?
12. How does your home group help you check your guidance against something other than your own wishful thinking?
13. What does it mean to you today that A.A. teaches prayer this way rather than as a way to get answers?
14. Where in your life is the sense of belonging Bill describes most present?
15. Where in your life is it still missing?

Where We're Going

Fifteen questions on what is becoming possible.

1. What does a deeper practice of conscious contact look like for you going forward?
2. What is one specific demand on God you are ready to bring down to a request?
3. What is one prayer for somebody else you are ready to release back to God's will?
4. What is one short prayer or phrase you want to keep close for hard moments?
5. Where in your life are you ready to stop forcing your own will under the cover of "guidance"?
6. What would it look like to start each day with the simple ask Bill suggests?
7. What would it look like to pause and renew the request in the middle of a hard decision this week?
8. Who in your life might be on the edge of their own deeper Step Eleven?
9. What does it look like in your life when you stop demanding answers on your terms?
10. What is one season of suffering you are still trying to extract a lesson from, that may simply need more time?
11. What would it look like to resume prayer this week if you have been in rebellion?
12. What does it mean to you that even when you cannot pray, you are not far from God?
13. What would it look like to live in the sense of belonging Bill describes as a settled condition rather than an occasional gift?
14. What is one thing you want to carry out of this meeting tonight?

15. What does it mean to you to keep practicing conscious contact for the rest of your life?

Closing Line

We came in demanding answers. We stay because we have learned that conscious contact is the answer.

Cross-Reference

Members studying Step Twelve, Part 1 alongside Step Eleven, Part 2 may notice a shared theme: conscious contact with God is what makes a spiritual awakening possible.

Step Twelve, Part 1

“Having had a spiritual awakening as the result of these Steps, we tried to carry this message to alcoholics, and to practice these principles in all our affairs.”

Part 1 of 3. This meeting covers the spiritual awakening, pages 106 to 110.

Anchor Phrase

He has now become able to do, feel, and believe that which he could not do before on his unaided strength and resources alone.

Alternatives, in case this one does not fit:

The joy of living is the theme of A.A.'s Twelfth Step, and action is its key word.

What he has received is a free gift, and yet usually, at least in some small part, he has made himself ready to receive it.

The doubter who still claimed that he hadn't got the “spiritual angle” would presently love God and call Him by name.

Background

Bill Wilson wrote Step Twelve for the 12&12 in 1953 as the longest and most carefully constructed chapter in the book. Part of his motivation was to clear up a misunderstanding about spiritual awakening that had followed A.A. since the 1939 publication of the Big Book. In the first edition Bill had used the phrase “spiritual experience,” which led many readers to imagine a sudden, dramatic conversion event, much like Bill's own white-light experience at Towns Hospital in December 1934. After hearing for years from members who were sober and changed but had never had such a dramatic moment, Bill added the appendix titled Spiritual Experience to later printings of the Big Book, drawing on William James's distinction between the sudden variety and what James called the educational variety of awakening. The first part of the Step Twelve essay continues that clarification. Bill defines awakening here in everyday terms anyone can recognize.

Setting the Stage

Bill Wilson opens Step Twelve with two anchoring statements. The theme of the Step is the joy of living. The key word is action. The Twelfth Step turns us outward toward the alcoholic who is still suffering, and it begins to translate the Steps into the whole of our lives.

The first half of the chapter is devoted to one question. What is a spiritual awakening? Bill writes that there are probably as many definitions as there are people who have had them. But each

genuine awakening has something in common with all the others. The most important meaning, he writes, is that the person has now become able to do, feel, and believe that which he could not do before on his unaided strength and resources alone. He has been granted a gift that amounts to a new state of consciousness and being. He has been set on a path. He has been transformed because he has laid hold of a source of strength he had previously denied himself. He finds himself in possession of a degree of honesty, tolerance, unselfishness, peace of mind, and love of which he had thought himself quite incapable.

The gift is free, Bill writes, and yet usually the person has made himself ready to receive it. The way A.A. makes ready to receive this gift is by practicing the Twelve Steps. Bill then walks through Steps One through Eleven as a single arc of preparation, from the amazing paradox of Step One, through the moral inventory and amends, to the deepening conscious contact of Step Eleven. The persistent use of meditation and prayer, he writes, opened the channel so that where there had been a trickle, there now was a river that led to sure power and safe guidance.

Bill closes the first half of the chapter with a quiet prediction. The doubter who still claims he has not got the spiritual angle, who still considers his beloved A.A. group his only higher power, will presently love God and call Him by name.

Where We Begin

Seven questions to set the room before reading.

1. When you hear the phrase spiritual awakening, what is the first thing that comes to mind?
2. What did you expect a spiritual awakening would look like before you came into A.A.?
3. What is one thing you can do, feel, or believe today that you could not do, feel, or believe before?
4. What does it mean to receive a gift?
5. What does it mean to be made ready to receive something?
6. When you hear the phrase “the joy of living,” what comes to mind?
7. What does action have to do with awakening for you?

Where We've Been

Fifteen questions on lived experience.

1. What did you think a spiritual awakening was supposed to look like when you first heard the phrase?
2. What did you think had to happen to you for you to be considered awakened?
3. What was the white-knuckle version of you in early sobriety like?

4. When did you first notice you were able to do something you previously could not do?
5. When did you first notice you were able to feel something you previously could not feel?
6. When did you first notice you were able to believe something you previously could not believe?
7. What is one honesty you found in yourself that you had thought you were incapable of?
8. What is one tolerance you found in yourself that you had thought you were incapable of?
9. What is one piece of unselfishness you found in yourself that you had thought you were incapable of?
10. What is one moment of peace of mind that surprised you?
11. What is one love you found in yourself that you had thought you were incapable of?
12. Looking back at Steps One through Eleven, which Step did the most preparation in you for the awakening?
13. Who in the rooms looked at you and saw the change before you saw it yourself?
14. When did you first hear yourself talking about God in a way you would not have recognized a year or two earlier?
15. What is one moment from early sobriety where you can now see, in retrospect, that you were being made ready?

Where We Stand

Fifteen questions on what the work has built.

1. What does spiritual awakening mean to you today, in your own words?
2. What is one thing you do regularly now that you could not have done on your own resources?
3. What is one thing you feel regularly now that you could not have felt on your own resources?
4. What is one thing you believe now that you could not have believed on your own resources?
5. What does the new state of consciousness Bill describes look like in your daily life?
6. What does the path Bill describes look like for you in this season of your sobriety?
7. Where in your life is the river running now where there used to be a trickle?
8. What is one piece of honesty you have come to possess that you had thought yourself incapable of?
9. What is one piece of unselfishness you have come to possess that you had thought yourself incapable of?

10. Where in your life is the joy of living most present right now?
11. Where in your life are you still mostly in white-knuckle mode rather than awakened mode?
12. How do you tell when you are operating from the source of strength Bill describes, and when you are operating from your own resources?
13. How does your home group keep awakening you in ways you cannot awaken yourself?
14. What part of your awakening do you most often forget you have received?
15. What does it mean to you to say, today, that this Step is a gift and not an achievement?

Where We're Going

Fifteen questions on what is becoming possible.

1. What does deeper awakening look like for you going forward?
2. What is one thing you would like to be able to do, feel, or believe that you cannot yet do on unaided resources?
3. Where in your life are you ready to be made more ready?
4. What does the joy of living look like for you in this next season?
5. What is one piece of honesty that is becoming possible in you?
6. What is one piece of tolerance that is becoming possible in you?
7. What is one piece of love that is becoming possible in you?
8. Who in your life might be on the edge of their own awakening?
9. What is one piece of your old self that is still asking to be transformed?
10. What does it look like to live as someone whose awakening is ongoing rather than finished?
11. Where in your life are you ready to claim a gift you have already received but not fully accepted?
12. What does it mean to you to come, eventually, to call your Higher Power by name in your own way?
13. What does it look like to keep practicing the first eleven Steps as preparation for a deeper awakening?
14. What is one thing you want to carry out of this meeting tonight?
15. What does it mean to you to keep waking up for the rest of your life?

Closing Line

We came in asleep. We stay because we are still waking up.

Cross-Reference

Members studying Step Twelve, Part 2 alongside Part 1 may notice a shared theme: an awakening that does not move us toward another suffering alcoholic is not yet complete.

Step Twelve, Part 2

“Having had a spiritual awakening as the result of these Steps, we tried to carry this message to alcoholics, and to practice these principles in all our affairs.”

Part 2 of 3. This meeting covers carrying the message and the danger of two-stepping, pages 110 to 117.

Anchor Phrase

Freely ye have received; freely give.

Alternatives, in case this one does not fit:

These are only the pains of growing up, and nothing but good can come from them if we turn more and more to the entire Twelve Steps for the answers.

When we are willing to place spiritual growth first, then and only then do we have a real chance.

Through A.A. we begin to learn right relations with people who understand us; we don't have to be alone any more.

Background

Bill Wilson wrote this section of Step Twelve in 1953 to correct a pattern he had watched develop in A.A. through the 1940s. Members would get sober, start sponsoring others, and convince themselves they were practicing the whole program when they were really practicing only the first Step and the carrying-the-message piece of the twelfth. Bill named this the two-stepping illusion. He had seen it produce members who were active, busy, and respected, but who got blindsided when life handed them a real difficulty. The two-stepping warning is one of his sharpest practical contributions to A.A. literature. The verse “Freely ye have received; freely give,” which Bill places at the center of this section, comes from the Gospel of Matthew. He quotes it without citation, the way someone would quote a familiar proverb, because by 1953 it had become part of A.A.'s working vocabulary.

Setting the Stage

The second part of Step Twelve answers a question. What does it actually look like to carry the message and to practice these principles in all our affairs? Bill Wilson begins with the most visible form of Twelfth Step work: sitting with the alcoholic who is still suffering. He writes that no satisfaction is deeper than a Twelfth Step job well done. To watch a person move from darkness to light, to see whole families reassembled, to see the alcoholic outcast received back into the

community, to watch someone awaken to a loving God in their life. That, Bill writes, is the substance of what we receive when we carry the message.

But Bill is careful to widen the definition. Twelfth Step work is not only the sponsor sitting on the edge of a hospital bed. It is also sitting in meetings and listening. It is speaking when our turn comes. It is making the coffee. It is setting up the chairs. The newcomer who first finds confidence and comfort in the laughter and talk after a meeting often does so because somebody quietly did the unspectacular work that made the room ready. Freely ye have received, Bill writes. Freely give.

Bill then names the pitfalls. We will set our hearts on a particular newcomer who then relapses. We will get a string of relapsed sponsees and become discouraged. Or we will swing the other way, get possessive of the sponsee who is staying sober, and start giving advice we have no business giving. We will be elevated to chairman and discover the temptation to overmanage. All of these, Bill writes, are only the pains of growing up. Nothing but good can come from them if we turn more and more to the entire Twelve Steps for the answers.

Then Bill names the deeper trap. He calls it the two-stepping illusion. The member who gets sober and starts carrying the message can begin to feel so good that he convinces himself the rest of the program is for somebody else. He is doing fine on Steps One and Twelve. The pink cloud lasts for a while. Then life hands him a great big lump he cannot swallow. A job lost. A marriage in crisis. A child harmed. A serious illness. Here, Bill writes, the two-stepper finds out he was never as well-equipped as he believed. The only answer is to switch to twelve-stepping. To return to the full program. To let spiritual growth become the priority that everything else serves.

Bill closes this section by describing the change in emotional security that follows. We used to dominate the people around us or depend on them too heavily. Both produced the same result: we ended up isolated and disappointed. The new way is partnership and brotherhood. We give without demanding repayment. We discover that people are drawn to us in a new way. And the deepest source of stability turns out to be God. When we depend on God, we no longer have to play God to our fellows, and we no longer have to lean on people in a way they cannot bear. Through A.A., Bill writes, we begin to learn right relations with people who understand us. We do not have to be alone any more.

Where We Begin

Seven questions to set the room before reading.

1. When you hear the phrase carry the message, what is the first thing that comes to mind?
2. What is one thing you have received freely that you want to give freely?
3. What kind of Twelfth Step work fits your life best?
4. What does it mean to grow up spiritually?

5. What does emotional security mean to you?
6. When have you dominated someone you cared about?
7. When have you depended on someone in a way that was too heavy for them to carry?

Where We've Been

Fifteen questions on lived experience.

1. Who was the first person you tried to carry the message to?
2. What did that conversation teach you about Twelfth Step work?
3. Who is one alcoholic you watched move from darkness into light up close?
4. Who is one alcoholic you set your heart on who relapsed, and what did you learn from that?
5. What did you learn about yourself the first time you became possessive of a newcomer?
6. What did you learn the first time you gave advice to a sponsee that you had no business giving?
7. What did the coffee-and-cake work or the setting-up work teach you that the speaking work could not?
8. When have you been in a two-stepping season, doing Step One and the carrying-the-message piece of Step Twelve while neglecting the rest?
9. When did the pink cloud first wear off for you?
10. When did life first hand you a big lump in sobriety that two-stepping could not carry you through?
11. What did you discover about your spiritual life in that hard moment?
12. What did emotional security look like in your drinking days, in the way you dominated or depended on people?
13. Who in your past did you try to turn into a protective parent?
14. Who in your past did you try to dominate as though they were a child?
15. When did you first feel that you did not have to be alone any more?

Where We Stand

Fifteen questions on what the work has built.

1. What does carrying the message look like in your life today?
2. What kinds of Twelfth Step work do you do that nobody sees?
3. What is one Twelfth Step job well done that you are still grateful for?

4. Where in your life today are you tempted to two-step rather than twelve-step?
5. Which Steps are you most tempted to skim when things are going well?
6. Where in your life are you currently being possessive of someone in recovery?
7. Where in your life are you currently giving advice that does not belong to you?
8. What does the pain of growing up look like in your service work now?
9. How do you tell when a setback in Twelfth Step work is a stepping-stone rather than a defeat?
10. Where in your life are you still trying to dominate the people around you?
11. Where in your life are you still depending on someone in a way that is too heavy?
12. What does partnership and brotherhood look like in your closest relationships today?
13. What does it mean to you today to give without demanding repayment?
14. How does your home group keep you out of the two-stepping illusion?
15. Where in your life is the deepest source of stability God rather than a person?

Where We're Going

Fifteen questions on what is becoming possible.

1. What is one form of Twelfth Step work you are ready to take on or deepen?
2. Who in your life is asking, in some form, for the message to be carried to them?
3. What is one piece of unspectacular service work you are ready to do?
4. Where in your life are you ready to stop two-stepping?
5. Which Step is asking for closer attention from you right now?
6. What is one piece of advice you are ready to stop giving so that the person can find their own answer?
7. What is one expectation of a sponsee or fellow member you are ready to let go of?
8. What is one big lump life has handed you that you are still learning how to twelve-step through?
9. Where in your life are you ready to place spiritual growth ahead of an instinct?
10. What does it look like to move toward partnership in a relationship where you have been dominating?
11. What does it look like to move toward partnership in a relationship where you have been leaning?
12. Who in your life might be on the edge of their own Twelfth Step?
13. What does it look like to live as someone who does not have to be alone any more?

14. What is one thing you want to carry out of this meeting tonight?
15. What does it mean to you to keep practicing this part of Step Twelve for the rest of your life?

Closing Line

We came in alone. We stay because the giving has set us free.

Cross-Reference

Members studying Step Twelve, Part 3 alongside Part 2 may notice a shared theme: carrying the message is where practicing these principles in all our affairs begins.

Step Twelve, Part 3

“Having had a spiritual awakening as the result of these Steps, we tried to carry this message to alcoholics, and to practice these principles in all our affairs.”

Part 3 of 3. This meeting covers practicing these principles in all our affairs: marriage, money, and ambition, pages 117 to 125.

Anchor Phrase

True ambition is the deep desire to live usefully and walk humbly under the grace of God.

Alternatives, in case this one does not fit:

Freedom from fear was more important than freedom from want.

True leadership depends upon able example and not upon vain displays of power or glory.

Money gradually became our servant and not our master.

Background

Bill Wilson wrote the closing section of Step Twelve in 1953 as a survey of the three areas where alcoholics most often run into trouble after the drinking has stopped: marriage and sex, money, and personal ambition. By that point Bill had been observing sober A.A. members for nearly two decades and had seen many of them get blindsided by problems that had nothing directly to do with alcohol. The “eminent psychologists and doctors” Bill cites in the section on ambition likely include Dr. Harry Tiebout and the colleagues around him, who in the 1940s had described alcoholics as childish, emotionally sensitive, and grandiose. Bill records the resentment with which early A.A. members received that verdict and the gradual recognition that the doctors had been right. The line “True ambition is the deep desire to live usefully and walk humbly under the grace of God” comes near the end of the section on personal ambition. The Steps half of the 12&12 then closes with two short paragraphs of summary and ends with the Serenity Prayer in third-person form. Bill chose the “true ambition” line deliberately as the heart of everything the program has been trying to teach.

Setting the Stage

The closing section of Step Twelve asks the biggest question the program has so far raised. Can we love the whole pattern of living as eagerly as we love the small segment of it we discover when we help another alcoholic? Can we bring the same spirit into our family lives, our

work, our place in the world? Bill Wilson walks through three areas where this question gets tested.

The first is marriage and partnership. Alcoholism in a household destroys the conditions for adult partnership. The spouse becomes the head of the house. The drinker becomes a sick, irresponsible child who has to be looked after. A pattern is set that may take a long time to undo. When the drinker gets sober and starts going to meetings, the spouse may resent that A.A. did what years of devotion could not. The drinker may get so wrapped up in A.A. that he is away from home more than he was when drinking. Bill writes that the work of repair is real and patient. The recovering alcoholic begins to behave like a partner instead of a bad boy. He firmly stops reckless romancing. He takes up his responsibilities again. For single members, and for the members Bill calls loners, A.A. offers other forms of belonging and partnership that are just as real and just as lasting.

The second area is money. Bill traces the alcoholic's pattern. We had been spendthrifts, throwing money around to please ourselves and impress others. Then in early sobriety we sometimes swung to the opposite extreme. The spectacle of all the wasted years threw us into panic. We became misers. We demanded complete financial security or else. Bill writes that this is still off balance. When a job is a means of getting money rather than an opportunity for service, when financial independence matters more than dependence on God, we are still the victims of unreasonable fears. The Twelve Steps slowly take those fears away. Money becomes our servant rather than our master. Bill names the discovery: freedom from fear is more important than freedom from want.

The third area is personal importance, power, ambition, and leadership. Bill writes that practically every boy in America dreams of becoming President. The healthy adult lets that dream go and learns to play well whatever cards life deals him. Bill calls this staying right size. Alcoholics struggle with right size. Bill recounts the doctors who described us as childish, emotionally sensitive, and grandiose, and the resentment with which we received that verdict, and the eventual recognition that they had been correct. False pride, he writes, is the reverse side of the coin marked Fear. We had to be number one people to cover up our deep-lying inferiorities. The recovered alcoholic stops trying to dominate. True leadership turns out to depend on example, not on display. And the deepest discovery is that we do not have to be distinguished to be useful and happy. True ambition, Bill writes near the close of the section, is the deep desire to live usefully and walk humbly under the grace of God. The Steps half of the 12&12 ends a few lines later with the Serenity Prayer.

Where We Begin

Seven questions to set the room before reading.

1. When you hear the phrase practicing these principles in all our affairs, what is the first thing that comes to mind?

2. What does partnership mean to you?
3. What does staying right size mean to you?
4. What is the difference between freedom from fear and freedom from want?
5. What does it mean to live usefully?
6. What does it mean to walk humbly?
7. What did you expect this final part of Step Twelve would feel like before you read it?

Where We've Been

Fifteen questions on lived experience.

1. What did partnership look like in your closest relationships during your drinking days?
2. What role did the people closest to you end up playing because of your drinking?
3. What did the work of returning to adult partnership look like for you in early sobriety?
4. When did you first start to behave like a partner instead of like the sick child in the relationship?
5. What did reckless romancing look like in your drinking days, if it was part of your story?
6. If you came into A.A. single, what did finding partnership outside of marriage look like for you?
7. What did money mean to you in your drinking days?
8. What did you spend money on to please yourself or impress others?
9. What did the swing from spendthrift to miser look like in early sobriety, if it happened to you?
10. When did the terrible fears about money first start to lose their grip on you?
11. What did your ambition look like in your drinking days?
12. When did you first hear the description “childish, emotionally sensitive, and grandiose” applied to alcoholics, and what was your reaction?
13. What did false pride sound like in your thinking when you were trying to be a number one person?
14. What did the deep-lying inferiority underneath the pride look like?
15. Who in the rooms first showed you what staying right size looked like?

Where We Stand

Fifteen questions on what the work has built.

1. What does adult partnership look like in your closest relationship today?

2. Where in your closest relationships are you still slipping into the role of the bad boy or the sick child?
3. Where in your closest relationships are you slipping into the role of the parent who has to manage somebody else's life?
4. What does it mean to you today that the work of repair is patient and long?
5. What does your relationship with money look like today?
6. Where in your life today is money still a master rather than a servant?
7. How do you tell the difference, now, between healthy planning and the panic Bill describes?
8. Where in your life is freedom from fear becoming more important to you than freedom from want?
9. What does true ambition look like in your life today?
10. Where in your life are you still trying to be a number one person?
11. Where in your life is false pride still the reverse side of fear?
12. What does staying right size look like for you in this season of your sobriety?
13. What does true leadership look like in your life right now?
14. What does it mean to you that you do not have to be distinguished to be useful and happy?
15. How does your home group keep you right sized in ways you cannot keep yourself right sized?

Where We're Going

Fifteen questions on what is becoming possible.

1. What does deeper practice of these principles in all your affairs look like for you going forward?
2. What is one relationship where you are ready to be more of a partner and less of a manager?
3. What is one relationship where you are ready to be more of a partner and less of a dependent?
4. Where in your life is reckless romance, in any form, still asking to be set down?
5. What does it look like for money to become a servant rather than a master in your life going forward?
6. What is one fear about money you are ready to bring before your Higher Power?
7. What is one piece of false pride you are ready to look at as the reverse side of a fear?

8. What is one piece of grandiosity you are ready to set down?
9. What does staying right size look like for you in the next year?
10. What does true leadership look like for you in your home, your group, or your work?
11. Who in your life might be on the edge of their own deeper Step Twelve?
12. What does it look like to live usefully in this season of your sobriety?
13. What does it look like to walk humbly under the grace of God in this season of your sobriety?
14. What is one thing you want to carry out of this meeting tonight?
15. What does it mean to you to keep practicing these principles in all your affairs for the rest of your life?

Closing Line

We came in chasing what we thought we wanted. We stay because we have learned how to live usefully and walk humbly.

Cross-Reference

Members beginning the study of the Twelve Traditions may notice a shared theme: the principles that keep the alcoholic alive are the same principles that keep the group alive.

Tradition One

“Our common welfare should come first; personal recovery depends upon A.A. unity.”

Anchor Phrase

The unity of Alcoholics Anonymous is the most cherished quality our Society has.

Alternatives, in case this one does not fit:

The clamor of desires and ambitions within him must be silenced whenever these could damage the group.

It becomes plain that the group must survive or the individual will not.

Our lives, the lives of all to come, depend squarely upon it.

Background

Bill Wilson placed Tradition One first because by 1953 he had spent fifteen years watching A.A. groups nearly destroy themselves over personalities, money, leadership, and theology. Groups in Akron, Cleveland, New York, and dozens of other cities had splintered or collapsed from 1937 onward, and only the willingness of a few members to put the group ahead of themselves had kept the Fellowship alive. The Traditions, in Bill's phrase, were beaten out on the anvil of group experience. Across his writings on the Traditions, Bill argued that the Twelve Traditions are to group survival what the Twelve Steps are to individual recovery. The Eddie Rickenbacker reference in this chapter draws on a 1942 story familiar to Bill's first readers. Rickenbacker and seven other men spent twenty-four days adrift in three small rafts in the Pacific after their B-17 ditched. Seven of the eight ultimately survived; one died during the ordeal, which Bill acknowledges in the chapter when he speaks of “the death of one.” Bill uses the image because it makes Tradition One concrete: a small group of people, alone on the sea, who survive only because each one keeps thinking of the others.

Setting the Stage

Tradition One is the floor under every other Tradition. Bill Wilson opens it with a stark sentence. The unity of Alcoholics Anonymous is the most cherished quality our Society has. Our lives, the lives of all to come, depend squarely upon it. Without unity, he writes, the heart of A.A. would cease to beat. Alcoholics would be back in their caves, and the gift would have been spent aimlessly.

Bill then names the question that puzzles every newcomer and every outside friend who looks at A.A. for the first time. If unity comes first, does the individual get swallowed up by the group?

Bill answers with a loud no. He writes that no fellowship on earth lavishes more devoted care upon its individual members, and none more jealously guards the individual's right to think, talk, and act as he wishes. No A.A. can compel another to do anything. The Steps are suggestions. The Traditions contain not a single "Don't." They say "We ought" and never "You must."

The chapter then explains the paradox. The A.A. member has to conform to the principles of recovery because his life depends on them. At first he goes along because he must. Later he discovers a way of life he actually wants. He finds he cannot keep what he has been given unless he gives it away. As soon as Twelfth Step work forms a group, another discovery follows. Most individuals cannot recover unless there is a group. The member realizes he is a small part of a great whole. No personal sacrifice is too great for the preservation of the Fellowship. The clamor of his own desires and ambitions has to be silenced whenever those could damage the group. The group must survive, Bill writes, or the individual will not.

The chapter closes on the Rickenbacker raft. A handful of people, saved from death but still afloat on a perilous sea, learn that none of them can become selfish of water or bread. Each must consider the others. That, Bill writes, is what A.A. has had to learn, town by town, hamlet by hamlet, for as long as the Fellowship has existed.

Where We Begin

Seven questions to set the room before reading.

1. When you hear the word unity, what is the first thing that comes to mind?
2. What is the difference between unity and uniformity?
3. What does it mean to put a common welfare ahead of your own preferences?
4. What is one group you have been part of that held together, and what held it?
5. What is one group you have been part of that fell apart, and what broke it?
6. What does it mean to depend on a group for something more than friendship?
7. What does it look like to walk into a room where the people there are committed to each other's welfare?

Where We've Been

Fifteen questions on lived experience.

1. What did you notice about how your home group worked together when you first walked in?
2. Who in the room was quietly putting the group ahead of themselves in those early days?
3. What did belonging to something larger than yourself feel like for the first time?
4. What did your isolation cost you before you got to A.A.?

5. What did self-will look like in you when you came in, in the way you talked about other people in the room?
6. When have you been the difficult person in a group?
7. When have you watched a personality come close to breaking something good?
8. When have you watched a member walk away from the group, and what happened to them?
9. When have you been on the receiving end of someone else's selfishness in a meeting?
10. When have you watched a disagreement in A.A. that was handled well, and what made the difference?
11. What is one time you had to silence your own desires and ambitions because they could have damaged the group?
12. What did your sponsor or a trusted member teach you about the group versus yourself?
13. What did you have to give up to become part of your home group?
14. What did you receive in return that you did not expect?
15. When did you first realize the group was keeping you sober?

Where We Stand

Fifteen questions on what the work has built.

1. What does common welfare look like in your home group right now?
2. What is one way you actively protect the unity of your group today?
3. Where in your group life are you still tempted to put your own preferences first?
4. What does it look like in you when the clamor of your own desires gets loud in a meeting?
5. How do you handle it when someone in the group does something you do not agree with?
6. How do you stay in a group when you are at odds with someone in it?
7. What is one personality in the room that has taught you something about your own ego?
8. What does it mean to you today to depend on the group rather than just attend it?
9. What does the right of every member to think, talk, and act as they wish ask of you when you do not like what they are saying?
10. Where in your group right now is the line between liberty and license being held?
11. How does the group keep you honest in ways you cannot keep yourself honest?
12. What does it look like when you choose the welfare of the group over being right?

13. Where in your life outside A.A. has Tradition One started to shape how you show up?
14. What does it feel like in your home group when the principle Bill names is working?
15. What does it feel like when it is not?

Where We're Going

Fifteen questions on what is becoming possible.

1. What does deeper unity look like for your group going forward?
2. Where in your group life is Tradition One asking you to grow?
3. What is one ambition or desire you may need to silence for the good of the group?
4. Who in your group might need to feel more included than they currently do?
5. What is one thing you could do this week to put common welfare ahead of your own preference?
6. What is one disagreement you can see coming, and how do you want to handle it differently?
7. What does it look like to carry the spirit of Tradition One into your family?
8. What does it look like to carry it into your workplace?
9. What is one personality you are still learning to love who is also in the rooms with you?
10. What does it mean to you that your sobriety depends on people you did not choose?
11. What do you want to give to your group that you have not yet given?
12. How can you help keep the door open for the next person walking in?
13. What does true belonging look like for you going forward?
14. What is one thing you want to carry out of this meeting tonight?
15. What does it look like to live as someone whose recovery depends on the recovery of others?

Closing Line

We came in alone. We stay because the group holds us, and we have learned how to hold the group.

Cross-Reference

Members studying Step One alongside this Tradition may notice a shared theme: neither the individual nor the group survives alone.

Tradition Two

“For our group purpose there is but one ultimate authority: a loving God as He may express Himself in our group conscience. Our leaders are but trusted servants; they do not govern.”

Anchor Phrase

The group was right and I was wrong; the voice on the subway was not the voice of God.

Alternatives, in case this one does not fit:

They become the real and permanent leadership of A.A.

Servants, not senators.

They do not drive by mandate; they lead by example.

Background

Bill Wilson placed Tradition Two second because by the early 1950s he had watched dozens of groups stumble over the question of authority. The personal story at the heart of this chapter is Bill's own, from 1938, when the proprietor of Towns Hospital in New York, Charles Towns, offered Bill a paid position as a lay therapist. Bill was broke. His wife Lois was working long hours at a department store and coming home to cook for the alcoholics they were boarding. The offer was generous and, on the surface, ethical. Bill came back to a meeting in his Clinton Street home ready to accept it. The group told him not to. Bill listened. The decision shaped A.A. permanently. From that point forward Bill refused all paid positions in connection with carrying the message, and the principle that no one would profit personally from A.A. work became one of the load-bearing beams of the Fellowship. Bill closes Tradition Two with this story because it is the clearest example he had of group conscience overruling a leader, and the leader recognizing that the group had been right.

Setting the Stage

Tradition Two answers a question that puzzles every newcomer and every outside observer. Who runs A.A.? The Society has no president who can govern, no treasurer who can compel dues, no board of directors who can throw a member out. No A.A. can give another A.A. a directive and enforce it. The friends gasp. There must be an angle somewhere. Then they read Tradition Two and learn that the sole authority in A.A. is a loving God as He may express Himself in the group conscience. This looks vague and naive to them at first, Bill writes. Then they look at A.A. history and start to see how it works.

Bill walks through a typical pattern. A good A.A. named John Doe moves to Middletown. He needs other alcoholics or he will not stay sober. He starts a group. He is the founder, and at first he is the boss. Soon his authority is shared with the first people he has helped. They become a self-appointed committee. The group booms. The founder and his friends, being human, start to bask a little in their glory. They decide it would be a good idea to keep a firm hand on A.A. in their town. Growing pains arrive. Panhandlers, lonely hearts, avalanches of problems. Then come the murmurs in the body politic, which swell into a loud cry: let's have an election. The group conscience is about to take over.

The election happens. If the founder and his friends served well, they may be reinstated for a time. If they resisted the rising democracy, they are quietly beached. Either way, the group now has a rotating committee with sharply limited authority. They are servants, not senators. They give no spiritual advice. They issue no orders. They do the chores that let the group function. They get promptly replaced at the next election if they try anything else.

Bill then asks the natural question. Does A.A. have a real leadership? Most emphatically, he writes, the answer is yes. He divides the deposed founders into two classes. The elder statesman sees the wisdom of the group's decision, holds no resentment, and sits quietly on the sidelines with his experience available when the group asks. The bleeding deacon stays consumed with self-pity, schemes for re-election, and sometimes hemorrhages so badly that he drinks. The elder statesmen become the real and permanent leadership of A.A. They lead by example, not by mandate. They are the voice through which group conscience often speaks.

The chapter closes with Bill's own story of the Towns Hospital offer and the meeting at Clinton Street where the group told him no. The voice on the subway, Bill writes, was not the voice of God. The true voice was welling up out of his friends. He listened, and he obeyed.

Where We Begin

Seven questions to set the room before reading.

1. When you hear the phrase group conscience, what is the first thing that comes to mind?
2. What does the phrase trusted servant mean to you?
3. What is the difference between leading by example and leading by mandate?
4. When have you watched a group make a better decision than any one person in it could have made?
5. When have you been certain about something and then been told no by people you trusted?
6. What does it mean to be governed by no one and answer to everyone?
7. What did you expect this Tradition would say before you read it?

Where We've Been

Fifteen questions on lived experience.

1. What did you think about authority and groups before you got to A.A.?
2. What did you expect would be running the place when you walked into your first meeting?
3. When did you first see the group conscience at work?
4. What is one decision your home group has made that surprised you in a good way?
5. What is one decision your home group has made that you initially disagreed with and later came to see was right?
6. Who in your group has shown you what trusted servant means in practice?
7. Who in your group most resembles an elder statesman as Bill describes them?
8. Have you ever been a bleeding deacon, even briefly, and what brought you out of it?
9. When have you watched a founder or longtime member quietly accept being replaced?
10. When have you watched the opposite, and what did it cost the group?
11. When did you first realize that the leaders in A.A. do not actually direct anybody?
12. When have you confused a personal hunch with divine guidance, the way Bill did on the subway?
13. When did a friend or sponsor function as the true voice you needed to hear?
14. What did you discover the first time you served the group in some small role?
15. What did you discover the first time you were a difficult member for the group to handle?

Where We Stand

Fifteen questions on what the work has built.

1. What does group conscience look like in your home group today?
2. What is one role you serve in your group right now, and what has it taught you?
3. Where in your group life are you tempted to govern rather than serve?
4. Where in your group life are you tempted to scheme for influence rather than trust the process?
5. What does it look like in you when you cannot let go of a position or a preference?
6. How do you tell the difference today between your own voice on the subway and the true voice welling up out of your friends?
7. What does it cost you when you mistake the first for the second?

8. What does it look like when an elder statesman in your group speaks, and how do you receive it?
9. What does it look like when a bleeding deacon in your group speaks, and how do you handle it?
10. Where in your group life are you a servant in Bill's sense of the word?
11. Where in your group life are you behaving as a senator instead?
12. How does your home group keep its leaders accountable without governing them?
13. What does the rotating committee in your group teach you about humility?
14. What does it mean to you today that A.A. has real leadership without any leader having authority over anyone?
15. How is Tradition Two doing its work in you right now?

Where We're Going

Fifteen questions on what is becoming possible.

1. What does deeper trust in group conscience look like for you going forward?
2. What is one position or preference you are ready to release to the group?
3. What is one piece of service you are ready to take on this year?
4. What is one piece of service you are ready to let go of so someone else can grow into it?
5. Who in your group is being prepared to lead by example, and how can you support them?
6. Where in your life outside A.A. would Tradition Two change how you show up?
7. What would it look like to bring this principle into your family?
8. What would it look like to bring it into your workplace?
9. What is one place in your life where you have been the founder who needs to step back?
10. What is one place in your life where you have been the bleeding deacon who needs to step forward and let go?
11. What does it mean to you to become someone whose quiet opinion is trusted in time?
12. What does it look like to listen for the group conscience before you reach for your own answer?
13. What would it mean for you to obey the true voice this week the way Bill did?
14. What is one thing you want to carry out of this meeting tonight?
15. What does it look like to live as someone whose only authority is a loving God as expressed in the conscience of the group?

Closing Line

We came in looking for who was in charge. We stay because we have found out.

Cross-Reference

Members studying Step Two alongside this Tradition may notice a shared theme: authority comes from a Power outside the self, and the group is one of the places that Power speaks.

Tradition Three

"The only requirement for A.A. membership is a desire to stop drinking."

Anchor Phrase

You are an A.A. member if you say so. You can declare yourself in; nobody can keep you out.

Alternatives, in case this one does not fit:

To take away any alcoholic's full chance was sometimes to pronounce his death sentence.

Who dared to be judge, jury, and executioner of his own sick brother?

Any alcoholic is a member of our Society when he says so.

Background

Bill Wilson wrote Tradition Three in 1953 with two specific stories at the front of his mind: the first from A.A.'s second year (1937), the second from 1938. The first involved a newcomer in 1937 who came to one of the first two A.A. groups carrying what Bill called another addiction even worse stigmatized than alcoholism, almost certainly a reference to the man's being gay at a time when that was both criminalized and treated as an illness. The elders considered turning him away. One member said five words that decided the question: What would the Master do? The newcomer stayed and became one of A.A.'s most effective Twelfth Step workers. The second story involved a man Bill names as Ed, an atheist who insisted A.A. could get along better without its God nonsense, and who stayed sober for months while baiting the entire group. When the elders tried to throw him out, he pointed at the foreword to the soon-to-be-published Big Book and read aloud the sentence that has since become Tradition Three. The elders backed down. Ed eventually relapsed, was deserted by the group, found a Gideon Bible in a hotel room, got sober again, and stayed sober until his death. Bill closes the chapter with a question A.A. old timers still ask: what if we had succeeded in throwing Ed out?

Setting the Stage

Tradition Three is one sentence and Bill Wilson writes that the sentence is packed with meaning. He paraphrases what it actually says to every serious drinker who walks through the door. You are an A.A. member if you say so. You can declare yourself in. Nobody can keep you out. No matter who you are, no matter how low you have gone, no matter how grave your emotional complications, no matter what your crimes, A.A. cannot deny you. The Fellowship does not want to keep you out. It is not afraid of you. It only wants you to get the same chance at sobriety the rest of us got.

Bill writes that this principle took years of harrowing experience to establish. In the early days A.A. groups felt fragile. New members were like flickering candles in a windstorm. The unspoken thought in every meeting was, which of us is next? Out of that fear came an avalanche of membership rules. Bill recounts the moment when the Foundation office asked every group to send in its list of protective regulations. The combined list, he writes, was a mile long. If every rule had been in force everywhere, nobody could have joined A.A. at all.

The old timers in those early years were resolved to admit nobody but the pure alcoholic. Anyone with additional complications was kept out. Beggars, prisoners, asylum patients, gay people, anyone who looked unrespectable. A fine-mesh fence went up around A.A. Bill is honest about the cause. We were grim because we felt our lives and homes were threatened. Fear, he writes, is the true basis of intolerance.

What changed was experience. The very people the early groups were afraid of turned out to be among A.A.'s greatest workers. The troublesome people became the principal teachers of patience and tolerance. The fence came down because the fence was killing people. Bill names it plainly. To take away an alcoholic's full chance was sometimes to pronounce his death sentence. Who, he asks, dared to be judge, jury, and executioner of his own sick brother?

The chapter then tells two stories that hammered the principle into permanence. The man with the double stigma, who was welcomed when the elders asked the question what would the Master do, and who went on to help thousands. And Ed, the atheist who stayed by quoting the foreword of the Big Book back at the elders, who eventually got sober for life. The chapter closes with the line Bill returns to again and again across the Traditions: the hand of Providence gave us a sign that any alcoholic is a member of our Society when he says so.

Where We Begin

Seven questions to set the room before reading.

1. When you hear the phrase the only requirement, what comes to mind?
2. What does it mean to declare yourself in to something?
3. What does it mean to keep somebody out?
4. When have you been the new person walking through the door of a room where you were not sure you belonged?
5. When have you watched a group keep someone out for the wrong reason?
6. What does fear have to do with intolerance, in your experience?
7. What did you expect this Tradition would say before you read it?

Where We've Been

Fifteen questions on lived experience.

1. What did you expect to be asked when you walked into your first A.A. meeting?
2. What did you bring with you that you were sure would disqualify you?
3. Who in your first meeting made you feel like you belonged?
4. What did it sound like when somebody welcomed you without conditions?
5. When did you first hear someone share something at a meeting that you thought ought to get them kicked out, but did not?
6. When have you watched the group quietly receive someone you would not have received yourself?
7. When have you been the difficult member, the one others were waiting to leave?
8. When have you wished, quietly or out loud, that someone in the room would just go?
9. When have you been afraid that someone in the room would harm the group?
10. What did your sponsor or a trusted member teach you about the only requirement?
11. When did you first realize that fear was the actual reason you wanted to keep someone out?
12. Who in your home group resembles Ed, the difficult member who stayed and lived?
13. Who in your home group resembles the newcomer with the double stigma, welcomed against the odds?
14. When have you watched someone be deserted by the group, the way Ed was deserted, and come back changed?
15. What is one judgment you used to hold about a kind of person in the rooms that you no longer hold?

Where We Stand

Fifteen questions on what the work has built.

1. What does the only requirement mean to you today, in practical terms?
2. Who is in your home group right now that an earlier version of A.A. might have kept out?
3. Where in your group life are you tempted to add an unwritten requirement of your own?
4. What unwritten requirements have you noticed creeping into A.A. culture around you?
5. What does it look like in your group when somebody walks in carrying more than alcoholism?
6. How does your group meet the newcomer who is loud, or angry, or hostile to the program?
7. How does your group meet the newcomer who is quiet, or scared, or hard to reach?
8. Where in your group life does fear of reputation still drive decisions about who belongs?

9. How do you tell the difference today between protecting the group and excluding a sick brother or sister?
10. What does it look like when you receive someone the way the group received the man with the double stigma?
11. What does it look like when you fail to receive them that way?
12. What has a troublesome member of your group taught you about patience and tolerance?
13. What is one judgment you are still working on letting go of?
14. How does your home group hold the line on the only requirement when it is tested?
15. Where in your life is Tradition Three doing its work in you right now?

Where We're Going

Fifteen questions on what is becoming possible.

1. What does deeper practice of Tradition Three look like for you going forward?
2. Who in your group right now needs to be received more fully, and what is your part in that?
3. What is one unwritten requirement you are ready to stop applying?
4. What is one fear you are ready to name as the real reason for an exclusion you have been making?
5. Where in your life outside A.A. is Tradition Three asking you to receive someone differently?
6. What would it look like to bring this principle into your family?
7. What would it look like to bring it into your workplace?
8. Who in your life is the difficult Ed in your story, and what would it look like to keep loving them?
9. Who in your life is the newcomer with the double stigma, and what would it look like to welcome them?
10. What would it mean to ask, in a real situation this week, what would the Master do?
11. What does it look like to live as someone who refuses to be the judge of another sick alcoholic?
12. What is one piece of your own respectability you are ready to lay down?
13. What does it look like to keep the door open for the next person walking in, whoever they are?
14. What is one thing you want to carry out of this meeting tonight?

15. What does it look like to live by the only requirement for the rest of your life?

Closing Line

We came in expecting to be turned away. We stay because the door does not close.

Cross-Reference

Members studying Step Three alongside this Tradition may notice a shared theme: the door opens to anyone willing to walk through it, and willingness is the only key.

Tradition Four

“Each group should be autonomous except in matters affecting other groups or A.A. as a whole.”

Anchor Phrase

Every group had the right to be wrong.

Alternatives, in case this one does not fit:

Don't take yourself too damn seriously.

An A.A. group had exercised its right to be wrong, and had performed a great service for Alcoholics Anonymous, because it had been humbly willing to apply the lessons it learned.

Sobriety had to be its sole objective. In all other respects there was perfect freedom of will and action.

Background

Bill Wilson wrote Tradition Four in 1953 as the chapter that celebrates A.A.'s capacity to learn from its own mistakes. The Middleton story Bill tells in this chapter is true, though the town name is changed. In A.A.'s early years an enthusiastic group attempted to build a three-story alcoholic center that combined a club, a treatment facility, and an educational project under one roof, financed largely by non-alcoholic donors. The Foundation office warned them in writing that ventures of this kind had come to sticky ends elsewhere. The group went ahead anyway. When the project collapsed, the lead promoter wrote to New York acknowledging the mistake and sent back a small card the size of a golf scorecard. The cover read “Middleton Group #1. Rule #62.” Inside was a single line: Don't take yourself too damn seriously. Rule 62 became one of the most quoted phrases in A.A. and shows up in clubhouses and meeting rooms to this day. Bill placed the story at the heart of this chapter because it captures the spirit of Tradition Four better than any abstract argument could. The group had the right to be wrong, was wrong, picked itself up with a laugh, and taught the rest of the Fellowship something in the process.

Setting the Stage

Bill Wilson opens Tradition Four by calling autonomy a ten-dollar word and then translating it into plain English. Every A.A. group can manage its affairs exactly as it pleases, except where A.A. as a whole is threatened. The same question that came up under Tradition One comes up again. Is that much liberty foolishly dangerous?

Bill answers from experience. Over the years, he writes, every conceivable deviation from the Steps and Traditions has been tried. We are largely a band of ego-driven individualists, and as

children of chaos we have defiantly played with every brand of fire. We have emerged unharmed, and, Bill thinks, wiser. The deviations themselves created a vast process of trial and error which, under the grace of God, brought the Fellowship to where it stands.

When the Traditions were first published in 1946, Bill writes, A.A. had become sure that a group could withstand almost any amount of battering. The group, like the individual, must eventually conform to whatever principles guarantee survival, but there was real safety in letting trial and error do its work. The original statement of the Tradition put it plainly. Any two or three alcoholics gathered together for sobriety may call themselves an A.A. group, provided that as a group they have no other affiliation. Two storm signals were posted. A group ought not do anything that would greatly injure A.A. as a whole. And a group ought not affiliate itself with anything or anybody else. Outside those two boundaries, freedom was complete. Every group had the right to be wrong.

The chapter then tells the Middleton story. An eager group in a small town dreamed up a great big alcoholic center: a club on the first floor, a hospital ward for drying out drunks on the second, an educational project on the third. A super-promoter sold the idea to wealthy townsfolk. The Foundation warned the group in writing that ventures mixing A.A. with medication and education had failed elsewhere. The group went ahead anyway, adopting sixty-one rules and regulations to make the operation foolproof. The center boomed for a moment and then collapsed in confusion. Drunks came in for one floor, ended up on another, and the whole project fell apart.

Then, Bill writes, a wonderful thing happened. The head promoter wrote to New York and admitted the experience. He sent along a small card the size of a golf scorecard. On the front it read Middleton Group, Rule 62. Inside was a single sentence. Don't take yourself too damn seriously. The group had exercised its right to be wrong, had been willing to learn the lesson, had picked itself up with a laugh, and had performed a service for the whole Fellowship. The chief architect, Bill writes, could laugh at himself standing in the ruins of his dream. That, Bill says, is the very acme of humility.

Where We Begin

Seven questions to set the room before reading.

1. When you hear the word autonomy, what is the first thing that comes to mind?
2. What does it mean for a group to have the right to be wrong?
3. When have you watched a group learn something only by trying it and failing at it?
4. What does it mean to take yourself too seriously?
5. When have you watched humility show up as laughter at one's own dream in ruins?
6. What does it mean for a group to keep its sole objective in view?
7. What did you expect this Tradition would say before you read it?

Where We've Been

Fifteen questions on lived experience.

1. What did you expect about how A.A. groups would be regulated when you first walked in?
2. What did you discover about the freedom of each group to make its own decisions?
3. What is one decision your home group has made that surprised you in its independence?
4. What is one experiment your home group tried that did not work?
5. What did the group do after the experiment failed?
6. When have you watched a group try to be all things to all people, the way the Middleton group did?
7. When have you watched a super-promoter at work in or around A.A.?
8. When have you watched a group take itself too seriously?
9. When did you first hear the phrase Rule 62, and what did it open up for you?
10. When have you watched a group affiliate itself with something it should not have, and what happened?
11. When did your home group last have to ask whether something it was doing affected A.A. as a whole?
12. Who in the rooms first taught you to laugh at yourself?
13. What is one rule you tried to live by in early sobriety that turned out to be your own invention?
14. When have you been on the receiving end of someone else's sixty-one rules and regulations?
15. When did you first realize the group was strong enough to survive its own mistakes?

Where We Stand

Fifteen questions on what the work has built.

1. What does autonomy look like in your home group right now?
2. What is the sole objective of your home group, and how does the group keep it in view?
3. Where in your group life is autonomy serving the primary purpose well?
4. Where in your group life is autonomy being used to dodge accountability?
5. What is one current decision your group is sitting with that calls for Tradition Four wisdom?
6. How does your group test whether a decision affects A.A. as a whole?

7. What does the right to be wrong look like in your group in practice?
8. What does it look like when your group exercises that right and then refuses to learn from the result?
9. What does it look like when your group exercises that right and is humble enough to apply the lesson?
10. How do you, personally, tell the difference between healthy experiment and quietly building a sixty-one-rule fortress?
11. Where in your group life is Rule 62 the most needed sentence right now?
12. How does your home group handle a strong personality with big ideas?
13. How does it handle the quieter members whose objections turn out to be right?
14. What does it mean to you today that the group, like the individual, must eventually conform to whatever principles guarantee survival?
15. Where in your group is Tradition Four still doing its work?

Where We're Going

Fifteen questions on what is becoming possible.

1. What does deeper practice of Tradition Four look like for your group going forward?
2. What is one experiment your group is considering that needs to be tested against the two storm signals?
3. Where in your group life is the sole objective in danger of being crowded out?
4. What is one affiliation, formal or informal, your group is being tempted toward?
5. What is one piece of advice from outside A.A. your group needs to hear and then weigh carefully?
6. What is one mistake your group has already made that you are ready to laugh at and learn from?
7. Where in your life outside A.A. is Tradition Four asking you to grant someone else the right to be wrong?
8. What would it look like to bring this principle into your family?
9. What would it look like to bring it into your workplace?
10. What is one place in your life where Rule 62 is the medicine you need this week?
11. What is one dream of yours that is in ruins right now, that you could stand in and laugh at?
12. What does it look like to live as someone who can laugh at himself the way the Middleton promoter did?

13. What does humility look like for you when one of your good ideas turns out not to be good enough?
14. What is one thing you want to carry out of this meeting tonight?
15. What does it mean to you to live with both freedom and responsibility for the rest of your life?

Closing Line

We came in expecting rules. We stay because we have learned how to laugh at ourselves and keep going.

Cross-Reference

Members studying Step Four alongside this Tradition may notice a shared theme: the group, like the individual, finds freedom on the other side of an honest accounting.

Tradition Five

"Each group has but one primary purpose: to carry the message to the alcoholic who still suffers."

Anchor Phrase

Shoemaker, stick to thy last.

Alternatives, in case this one does not fit:

Better do one thing supremely well than many badly.

We can seldom keep the precious gift of sobriety unless we give it away.

The only thing that matters is that he is an alcoholic who has found a key to sobriety.

Background

Bill Wilson wrote Tradition Five in 1953 as one of the shortest essays in the book, anchored by a single Twelfth Step story. The story is widely understood among A.A. historians to be drawn from one of Bill's own Twelfth Step visits to Towns Hospital. The 12&12 attributes it to an unnamed member. He visited Towns Hospital looking for a prospect, and Dr. William Silkworth, the physician who had first told Bill that alcoholism was a malady of mind and body, pointed him to a hostile Irishman on the third floor. The man's first instinct was to assume he was being recruited into a religious sect. Bill avoided the trap by refusing to argue about religion at all. He told the man he was a conceited Irishman who thought he could run the whole show. The line broke through. The Irishman got sober, stayed sober for years, and later said: my sponsor sold me one idea, and that was sobriety. At the time, I couldn't have bought anything else. Bill closes the chapter with that line because it captures the heart of the Tradition. The single thing A.A. has to offer is the single thing that has to be carried.

Setting the Stage

Bill Wilson opens Tradition Five with an old proverb. Shoemaker, stick to thy last. Better do one thing supremely well than many things badly. Around this single principle, he writes, our Society gathers in unity. The very life of the Fellowship requires its preservation.

Bill draws an analogy. A.A. is like a group of physicians who have stumbled onto a cure for cancer. Each doctor may have his own specialty. Each may wish at times to go back to his chosen field. But once they recognize that only their united effort produces the cure, they set their other ambitions aside, whatever the personal cost. The members of A.A., Bill writes, are bound by the same obligation. The unique ability of one alcoholic to identify with another and bring recovery to him does not depend on learning, eloquence, or any special skill. The only

thing that matters is that he is an alcoholic who has found a key to sobriety. This gift, Bill writes, passes easily from one alcoholic to another. It is the one aim that animates A.A.s around the globe.

There is a second reason for the singleness of purpose. Bill names it as the great paradox of A.A. We can seldom keep the precious gift of sobriety unless we give it away. A group of doctors with a cancer cure might be conscience-stricken if they neglected their mission, but neglect would not kill them. For the alcoholic, neglect of the suffering newcomer is unremitting danger to his own life and sanity. Under the combined pressure of self-preservation, duty, and love, A.A. has concluded that it has but one high mission: to carry the message to those who do not know there is a way out.

Bill closes the chapter with the Towns Hospital story. The Irishman who scoffed at A.A., assumed the visitor was proselytizing for a religious sect, then listened when the visitor refused to argue religion and named the real problem out loud: a conceited Irishman who thinks he can run the whole show. Bill spells out what would have gone wrong if the visitor had carried anything other than the one message. If he had argued about religion. If he had offered money. If he had offered education, or hospitals, or rehabilitation, or advice on the man's marriage and business. The answer is the line the Irishman himself returned to years later. My sponsor sold me one idea, and that was sobriety. At the time, I couldn't have bought anything else.

Where We Begin

Seven questions to set the room before reading.

1. When you hear the phrase primary purpose, what is the first thing that comes to mind?
2. What does it mean to do one thing supremely well?
3. What is one gift you have been given that you can only keep by giving it away?
4. What does it mean to carry a message rather than give advice?
5. Who is the alcoholic who still suffers in your imagination right now?
6. When have you been on the receiving end of someone who knew what to offer and what to withhold?
7. What did you expect this Tradition would say before you read it?

Where We've Been

Fifteen questions on lived experience.

1. Who was the first person to carry the message to you?
2. What did they offer you that you could actually receive in that moment?
3. What did they not offer you that they might have been tempted to offer?

4. What were you trying to argue about when you came in that had nothing to do with sobriety?
5. What was your version of the Irishman's "I'll fix my wife, my partner, and my drinking myself"?
6. When did somebody name the real problem in you, the way Bill named conceited Irishman in the story?
7. How did that land?
8. What was the first piece of A.A. message you found you could buy?
9. What other thing might you have been sold in early sobriety that you would have refused?
10. Who was the first newcomer you tried to carry the message to?
11. What did you offer that helped, and what did you offer that did not?
12. When have you watched a sponsor or trusted member stick to the message and refuse to drift?
13. When have you watched somebody in A.A. try to be a therapist, a financial advisor, or a marriage counselor instead?
14. When did you first feel restless and realize that carrying the message was the medicine you needed?
15. When did you first understand that giving the message away was how you got to keep it?

Where We Stand

Fifteen questions on what the work has built.

1. What does the primary purpose look like in your home group today?
2. What does it look like in your personal Twelfth Step work?
3. Where in your group life is the primary purpose most clearly in view?
4. Where in your group life is it being crowded out by something else?
5. What is one thing your group does well that supports the primary purpose?
6. What is one thing your group is tempted to take on that would distract from it?
7. When you sit with a newcomer, how do you tell what they can buy in that moment and what they cannot?
8. Where in your Twelfth Step work are you tempted to argue about religion the way Bill almost did?
9. Where in your Twelfth Step work are you tempted to offer money, advice, or rescue rather than the message?

10. How do you handle a newcomer whose first reaction to A.A. is hostile, the way the Irishman's was?
11. What does the gift Bill describes feel like passing through you to another alcoholic?
12. What does it feel like in you when you have not carried the message in a while?
13. How does your home group hold each member accountable to the primary purpose?
14. What does it look like in your life when you stick to your last as a shoemaker?
15. Where in your life is Tradition Five doing its work in you right now?

Where We're Going

Fifteen questions on what is becoming possible.

1. Who in your life is the alcoholic who still suffers, in this season?
2. What is one piece of message you are being asked to carry this week?
3. Where in your group life is the primary purpose asking to be brought back into focus?
4. What is one good thing your group is doing that is not the main thing?
5. What is one ambition for your group that has to be set aside for the sake of the primary purpose?
6. What does sticking to your last look like for you going forward?
7. Where in your Twelfth Step work are you ready to offer less, not more?
8. What does it look like to refuse to argue with a newcomer about what does not matter?
9. What does it look like to name the real problem the way the visitor named it in Bill's story?
10. Who in your life right now is the conceited Irishman in some form, and what would it look like to keep loving him?
11. What is one piece of restless energy you want to channel into carrying the message this week?
12. Where in your life outside A.A. is Tradition Five teaching you to do one thing well rather than many things badly?
13. What does it look like to live as someone whose first move when troubled is to carry the message?
14. What is one thing you want to carry out of this meeting tonight?
15. What does it mean to you to keep one primary purpose in view for the rest of your life?

Closing Line

We came in hoping to be given something. We stay because we have learned how to give it away.

Cross-Reference

Members studying Step Five alongside this Tradition may notice a shared theme: the alcoholic and the group both find their purpose in honest exchange with another human being.

Tradition Six

“An A.A. group ought never endorse, finance, or lend the A.A. name to any related facility or outside enterprise, lest problems of money, property, and prestige divert us from our primary purpose.”

Anchor Phrase

We of Alcoholics Anonymous could not be all things to all men, nor should we try.

Alternatives, in case this one does not fit:

The moment we saw that we had an answer for alcoholism, it was reasonable, or so it seemed at the time, for us to feel that we might have the answer to a lot of other things.

Alcoholics Anonymous saved my life, and it comes first.

Problems of money, property, and prestige divert us from our primary purpose.

Background

Bill Wilson wrote Tradition Six in 1953 to capture two decades of A.A. learning the hard way that the Fellowship could not be all things to all men. The chapter draws on A.A.'s early growth years, when its success with alcoholism led members to imagine they had the answer to almost everything: hospitals, education, drug addiction, criminal justice, depression, labor disputes, religious differences, even world peace. Bill notes wryly that most alcoholics are bankrupt idealists who, having failed at perfection, settled for the bottle. The closing story of the chapter is true. In the years before this Tradition was written, a distilling industry trade association tried to hire an A.A. member as a publicity director for a public education campaign that would distinguish responsible drinking from problem drinking. The member's full name and his A.A. membership were both to appear in the advertising. The man came to the New York office, saw the conflict for himself, and turned the job down with the line Bill quotes: Alcoholics Anonymous saved my life, and it comes first. Bill closes the chapter with that line because it states Tradition Six more plainly than the Tradition itself does.

Setting the Stage

Bill Wilson opens Tradition Six by describing the heady early years when A.A. members started to believe their answer for alcoholism might be the answer for almost anything. The list of dreams is long. A chain of A.A. hospitals. A.A.-rewritten school and medical textbooks. A.A. work with skid-row derelicts under a kind of quarantined confinement. A.A. parole programs for alcoholics in custody. A.A. work with drug addicts and criminals. A.A. therapy groups for

depressives and paranoids, the deeper the neurosis the better. A.A. mediation between labor and capital. A.A. cleanup of national politics. A.A. as the bridge between religion and medicine. A.A. as the spearhead of a new spiritual advance that would transform the world.

Bill is honest about why these dreams felt so plausible. Most alcoholics, he writes, are bankrupt idealists. Most of us had wanted to do great good, perform great deeds, embody great ideals. We were perfectionists who, having failed at perfection, settled for the bottle and the blackout. Then A.A. brought us within reach of our highest expectations. Why would we not share our way of life with everyone?

We tried. A.A. hospitals bogged down because too many busybody cooks spoiled the broth. A.A. groups went into education, started publicly endorsing brands of treatment, and people grew confused about what A.A. actually was. A.A. members thumped tables in legislative committee rooms. Even inside the Fellowship we had to remove the A.A. name from clubs and Twelfth Step houses, because the moment money, property, and prestige entered the picture, the primary purpose began to slip out of sight.

The lesson, Bill writes, became a deep-rooted conviction. In no circumstances could A.A. endorse any related enterprise, no matter how good. The Fellowship could not be all things to all men, nor should it try.

The chapter closes with the distilling-industry story. A large alcohol trade association proposed a public education campaign distinguishing acceptable drinking from problem drinking. They wanted to hire an A.A. member with public relations experience to head it. The member came to A.A. headquarters and asked whether anything in the Tradition prevented him from taking the job. At first glance the work looked unobjectionable. Then the catch surfaced. His name and his A.A. membership would both appear in the advertising. To millions of people it would look like A.A. was endorsing the liquor industry's view of drinking. The member did not need to be persuaded. He said, "Great guns. Of course I can't take the job. Alcoholics Anonymous saved my life, and it comes first." With that, Bill writes, our friend had said everything that needed saying about endorsements.

Where We Begin

Seven questions to set the room before reading.

1. When you hear the word endorsement, what comes to mind?
2. What does it mean for one group to lend its name to another?
3. What is the difference between supporting a good cause as an individual and dragging a whole group into it?
4. When have you watched a good cause distract people from the main one?
5. What does it mean for a group to keep its primary purpose in view under pressure?

6. What does the phrase “all things to all men” mean to you?
7. What did you expect this Tradition would say before you read it?

Where We've Been

Fifteen questions on lived experience.

1. What did you think A.A. would help you fix when you first got sober?
2. What did you discover A.A. is actually for?
3. What did the bankrupt idealist Bill describes look like in you when you came in?
4. What great deed did you want to perform with your sobriety in the early days?
5. When did you first try to take what you had in A.A. and apply it to something else and watch it bog down?
6. When have you watched A.A. members try to be therapists, doctors, or attorneys for each other?
7. When have you watched somebody use their A.A. connection to promote a business, a book, or a treatment program?
8. When have you watched a good cause try to attach itself to A.A.?
9. When did you first notice the difference between A.A. itself and the related facilities and clubs that grew up around it?
10. What did your sponsor or a trusted member teach you about the dangers of money, property, and prestige?
11. When did you first see a controversy in or near A.A. that came from somebody mixing the A.A. name with something else?
12. When have you seen A.A. members involved with treatment, education, or recovery industry work, and how did they keep it separate?
13. When have you watched outside money cause turmoil in or around A.A.?
14. What did you almost get pulled into in early sobriety that would have mixed your A.A. identity with something else?
15. What did you learn the hard way about A.A. not being all things to all men?

Where We Stand

Fifteen questions on what the work has built.

1. What does the primary purpose look like in your home group today?
2. Where in your group life are you tempted to lend the A.A. name to a related cause?

3. What outside enterprise, however worthy, has recently tried to attach itself to your group?
4. How did your group respond?
5. What does it look like when an A.A. member uses their A.A. identity to promote something outside A.A.?
6. How do you tell the difference today between a member's personal involvement in a cause and the group endorsing it?
7. Where in your group life does money, property, or prestige threaten to divert from primary purpose?
8. What does it look like when prestige starts to creep into group decisions?
9. What does it look like when money does?
10. What does it look like when property does?
11. How does your home group keep its name unattached to other organizations, however good?
12. What does the distilling-industry story teach you about how to evaluate an opportunity today?
13. Where in your life are you tempted to think A.A. should weigh in on a public question?
14. How does your group handle members who blur the line in public?
15. Where in your group is Tradition Six doing its work right now?

Where We're Going

Fifteen questions on what is becoming possible.

1. What does deeper practice of Tradition Six look like for your group going forward?
2. What is one place where your group needs to firm up its boundaries around money, property, or prestige?
3. What is one outside cause you personally care about that you can support without dragging A.A. into it?
4. What is one opportunity in your life right now that would require you to break Tradition Six to take?
5. Where in your life outside A.A. are you tempted to be all things to all men?
6. What would it look like to do one thing well rather than many things partly?
7. What would it look like to say, in your own words, that A.A. saved my life and comes first?
8. Where in your life is the bankrupt idealist still trying to run the show?

9. Where in your life have great expectations of yourself crowded out the simple work in front of you?
10. What does it look like to live as someone whose A.A. name is unattached to outside interests?
11. What does it look like to support a good cause without claiming a Fellowship-wide endorsement for it?
12. Who in your life might be on the edge of their own Tradition Six moment?
13. What is one piece of money, property, or prestige you are ready to refuse on Tradition Six grounds?
14. What is one thing you want to carry out of this meeting tonight?
15. What does it mean to you to keep A.A. unattached for the rest of your life?

Closing Line

We came in wanting A.A. to fix everything. We stay because we have learned what A.A. is actually for.

Cross-Reference

Members studying Step Six alongside this Tradition may notice a shared theme: readiness to let go of what we love, in service of what is essential.

Tradition Seven

“Every A.A. group ought to be fully self-supporting, declining outside contributions.”

Anchor Phrase

There was a place in A.A. where spirituality and money would mix, and that was in the hat.

Alternatives, in case this one does not fit:

Self-supporting alcoholics? Who ever heard of such a thing?

Whoever pays the piper is apt to call the tune.

The irresponsible had become responsible.

Background

Bill Wilson wrote Tradition Seven in 1953 as a chapter about the slow, painful discovery that A.A. had to pay its own way. Two stories anchor the chapter. The first is Bill's own, from the early 1940s, after Jack Alexander's Saturday Evening Post article in 1941 set off a flood of mail to the Foundation office. Bill spent one morning ranting about tightwad A.A. members who would not send a dollar a year to keep the office running. That same day he gave five dollars to a relapsed friend, then dropped a dime in the hat at his home group, then went home and realized which gesture had been ego and which had been responsibility. The second story is the trustees' 1948 decision to refuse a ten-thousand-dollar bequest from the will of a deceased woman who had found sobriety in A.A. The Foundation desperately needed the money. The trustees calculated that another half million dollars was already set aside for A.A. in the wills of living donors. They voted unanimously to decline the bequest and to make that refusal permanent policy. The principle of corporate poverty, Bill writes, was firmly and finally embedded in the Tradition that day.

Setting the Stage

Bill Wilson opens Tradition Seven with disbelief and a little humor. Self-supporting alcoholics? Who ever heard of such a thing? Yet, he writes, that is what we have to be. The principle is telling evidence of the change A.A. has wrought in its members. Active alcoholics, he writes, scream that they have no troubles money cannot cure. Always we have had our hands out. So when a society made entirely of alcoholics announces that it intends to pay its own bills, that is real news.

The chapter then traces a long swing. In the early years, everyone in A.A. was broke. Members assumed people ought to give them money. People with money disagreed. They figured it was

time the sober alcoholics paid their own way. So A.A. stayed poor because it had to. There was a second reason for the poverty, Bill writes with a half-smile. Alcoholics would spend lavishly on a single Twelfth Step call but had a terrific aversion to dropping money in the meeting hat for group purposes. We were, in Bill's words, as tight as the bark on a tree. A.A. as a movement stayed broke while individual members grew prosperous.

Bill names the alcoholic's all-or-nothing pattern. As A.A. left infancy and entered adolescence, the swing went the other way. Now the slogan became you cannot mix A.A. and money. Some groups refused to keep a cent in their treasury. The pendulum swung because some members had tried to make money off their A.A. connections, and outside benefactors had endowed clubhouses only to start interfering. One donor's son became the chief patient at the hospital he had paid for. One five-thousand-dollar gift created havoc in a group for years. The pendulum finally settled in the middle. Meeting places cost something. Small offices needed phones and a few full-time secretaries. The newcomer coming in the door had to find someone who could answer the call. Those small services would be paid for by the members themselves.

Then Bill tells his own story. The morning the mail came pouring in after the Saturday Evening Post article, Bill paced the office ranting about cheap A.A. members who would not send a dollar a year. Then an old acquaintance with an awful hangover wandered in. Bill, on a salary of thirty dollars a week, peeled off a five-dollar bill and handed it over, feeling especially virtuous. That night at the 24th Street Clubhouse the treasurer made a timid appeal because the landlord was about to evict them. The hat came around. Bill, busy converting the newcomer next to him, fumbled in his pocket, came up with a fifty-cent piece, decided it looked like a lot, and dropped it back. He fished out a dime. Then he woke up. The five dollars to the slippee had been ego. The dime in the hat had been the truth about him. There is a place, he realized, where spirituality and money do mix, and that is in the hat.

The second story is the 1948 trustees' decision on the ten-thousand-dollar bequest. The Foundation was strapped. The reserve was melting. Members argued for taking the money and accepting all such gifts in the future. The opposition pointed to a half million dollars already set aside for A.A. in living members' wills, and to the inevitable chain reaction that would follow. Whoever pays the piper, Bill writes, is apt to call the tune. A wealthy Foundation would soon invent schemes to do good with its money, the rank-and-file member would shrug and stop bothering to contribute, and the trustees would drift loose from the Fellowship that was supposed to direct them. The trustees declared for corporate poverty. They declined the ten thousand dollars and made the refusal permanent policy. When the story became public, editorial reaction at home and abroad was strong. A.A. had revived an ideal its era had almost forgotten. The irresponsible, Bill writes, had become responsible.

Where We Begin

Seven questions to set the room before reading.

1. When you hear the phrase fully self-supporting, what comes to mind?
2. What does it mean to pay your own way?
3. When have you watched outside money cause trouble in a group you were part of?
4. What does the phrase “whoever pays the piper calls the tune” mean to you?
5. What did you assume about money and A.A. before you read this chapter?
6. What does it look like in a group when responsibility has become a shared practice?
7. What did you expect this Tradition would say before you read it?

Where We've Been

Fifteen questions on lived experience.

1. What did money look like in your drinking days?
2. What did you tell yourself was the cause of your money problems back then?
3. Who paid for your drinking, directly or indirectly?
4. When did you first put money in the hat at a meeting?
5. What did that small act mean to you at the time?
6. When did you first realize that paying your own way was part of staying sober?
7. When have you been the slippee in someone else's story, dependent on another person's generosity?
8. When have you been the one quietly handed a five-dollar bill that you actually needed?
9. When have you watched ego dress itself up as generosity, the way Bill describes in his own story?
10. When have you been tight as the bark on a tree about the meeting hat?
11. When have you watched a group take outside money and regret it?
12. When have you watched a group accept a gift that came with strings attached?
13. When did you first start contributing to your home group at a level that actually cost you something?
14. When did you first start contributing beyond your home group to district, area, or General Service Office?
15. What did it feel like to know your dollar was helping keep the door open for the next person?

Where We Stand

Fifteen questions on what the work has built.

1. What does fully self-supporting look like in your home group today?
2. What does your group do with the money in the hat?
3. Where does the money go beyond your home group?
4. Where in your group life is responsibility being shared well?
5. Where in your group life is it being carried by too few people?
6. How does your group handle a member who is broke and cannot contribute right now?
7. How does your group handle a member who has plenty and contributes nothing?
8. What does it look like when somebody tries to make a large donation in a way that gives them influence?
9. How does your group decline outside contributions when they are offered?
10. What does corporate poverty mean to you in practice today?
11. Where in your group life is the ego-feeding generosity Bill describes still showing up?
12. How do you tell the difference today between a gift that supports the work and a gift that calls a tune?
13. What does it mean to you that you are now one of the responsible alcoholics the editorials wrote about?
14. How does Tradition Seven affect the way you handle your own money outside A.A.?
15. Where is Tradition Seven doing its work in you right now?

Where We're Going

Fifteen questions on what is becoming possible.

1. What does deeper self-support look like for your group going forward?
2. What is one way your group can become less dependent on the same few contributors?
3. What is one piece of service work that needs funding your group is not currently funding?
4. Where in your contribution to A.A. is there room to grow?
5. What is one outside contribution your group needs to be ready to decline?
6. Where in your life outside A.A. is Tradition Seven asking you to pay your own way?
7. Where in your life are you still expecting somebody else to cover for you?
8. Where in your life have you been picking up costs that are not yours to pick up?
9. What does it look like to live as someone who pays the piper for himself so nobody else calls his tune?

10. What does it look like to live as someone who can refuse a generous gift that would cost too much?
11. Who in your life might be on the edge of their own Tradition Seven moment?
12. What does it mean to you to be one of the responsible alcoholics now?
13. What is one piece of money, property, or prestige you are ready to refuse this year?
14. What is one thing you want to carry out of this meeting tonight?
15. What does it mean to you to keep paying your own way for the rest of your life?

Closing Line

We came in with our hand out. We stay because we have learned how to keep the door open by paying our own way.

Cross-Reference

Members studying Step Seven alongside this Tradition may notice a shared theme: self-support and humility belong together, in the life of the alcoholic and in the life of the group.

Tradition Eight

“Alcoholics Anonymous should remain forever nonprofessional, but our service centers may employ special workers.”

Anchor Phrase

Our Twelfth Step is never to be paid for, but those who labor in service for us are worthy of their hire.

Alternatives, in case this one does not fit:

At the point of professionalism, money and spirituality do not mix.

Alcoholics simply will not listen to a paid twelfth-stepper.

She was not professionalizing the Twelfth Step; she was just making it possible.

Background

Bill Wilson wrote Tradition Eight in 1953 to resolve one of the longest-running internal arguments in A.A.'s first two decades. From the early 1940s onward, members had accused each other of professionalizing A.A. whenever someone took paid work that touched alcoholism in any way. Caretakers who swept clubhouse floors, cooks who fried hamburgers, secretaries at the Foundation office, the authors of A.A. books, members who took jobs at hospitals or rest homes or industry, members who became researchers or social workers in the alcohol field, all of them got called professionals at one point or another. Bill uses this chapter to draw what he calls a plain line of cleavage. Twelfth Step work itself, sponsor to newcomer, can never be sold. But the chores that make Twelfth Step work possible can be paid for and ought to be. The phrase “the laborer is worthy of his hire” is the same line Bill cites in Tradition Two from the Towns Hospital subway story, where Bill once heard it as guidance from God and the Clinton Street group corrected him. He uses it here in its proper place, as scripture rather than as a self-justification for personally profiting from carrying the message.

Setting the Stage

Bill Wilson opens Tradition Eight with a clean statement. A.A. will never have a professional class. We have begun to grasp, Bill writes, the old line “freely ye have received, freely give.” At the point of professionalism, money and spirituality do not mix. Almost no recovery from alcoholism has ever been brought about by the world's best professionals, whether medical or religious. Bill is careful not to criticize professionalism in other fields. He simply records the fact that it does not work for us. Every time A.A. has tried to professionalize the Twelfth Step, the

single purpose has been defeated. Alcoholics will not listen to a paid Twelfth Stepper. The money motive compromises the person who tries it.

Bill then takes up the long argument. Few subjects have caused more contention inside the Fellowship than professionalism. Caretakers who swept floors. Cooks who fried hamburgers. Secretaries in offices. Authors writing books. All of them got attacked as professionals. Even greater fury erupted when A.A. members took jobs as personnel managers in industry, as nurses on alcoholic wards, as educators, as managers of rest homes and farms for alcoholics. The charge was always the same. A.A. knowledge was being sold for money. These people were professionals.

The line of cleavage, Bill writes, finally appeared. The Twelfth Step itself cannot be sold. There A.A. had been wise. But forbidding the Fellowship to hire service workers, or forbidding any A.A. member from carrying their experience into other fields as a citizen, had been the counsel of fear. Bill walks through the practical examples. A club has to be habitable and hospitable. Volunteers got tired of sweeping floors seven days a week. The empty club could not answer the phone, and a key in the wrong drunk's pocket meant trouble. Somebody had to be there. Hiring an alcoholic to do the job was simple service, not professionalization. The Foundation office and intergroup offices needed full-time secretaries who knew the A.A. pitch. Bill tells the story of a secretary at the Foundation office who answered the phone dozens of times a day, listened to twenty wailing wives, arranged hospitalization and sponsorship for ten newcomers, and got diplomatic with the irate drunk who complained about the job she was doing and how she was overpaid. Calling her a professional A.A., Bill writes, was nonsense. She was not professionalizing the Twelfth Step. She was making it possible.

Bill closes the chapter with the harder question. What about A.A. members who take outside jobs in the alcohol field? Researchers, educators, personnel officers, social workers, alcohol commission staff, the people who buy and run rest homes for alcoholics? Are they professionalizing A.A.? Bill's answer is no, members who take such careers do not professionalize the Twelfth Step. The road to that conclusion was long. The old confusion, Bill admits, had a real cause. Members who took those jobs used to break their anonymity to thump for their employer, and the A.A. name got dragged into causes that had nothing to do with sobriety. Once anonymity at the public level had become settled practice, the fear largely went away. A.A. members can carry their experience into wider fields as citizens. Everybody gains. The Twelfth Step itself, Bill writes, is never to be paid for. But those who labor in service for the Fellowship are worthy of their hire.

Where We Begin

Seven questions to set the room before reading.

1. When you hear the word professional, what comes to mind?
2. What does it mean for something to be sold?

3. What does it mean for something to be freely given?
4. What is the difference between Twelfth Step work and the chores that make Twelfth Step work possible?
5. When have you watched a money motive change the spirit of a thing?
6. What does it mean for a worker to be worthy of his hire?
7. What did you expect this Tradition would say before you read it?

Where We've Been

Fifteen questions on lived experience.

1. When did somebody first carry the message to you without asking for anything in return?
2. What did that free quality teach you about A.A.?
3. When have you watched a paid Twelfth Stepper at work, and what did you notice?
4. When have you watched a sponsor take money from a sponsee in some form, and what happened?
5. When did you first understand the difference between A.A.'s Twelfth Step and the alcoholism treatment industry around it?
6. When have you worked or volunteered in the recovery field as a member of A.A., and how did you keep the line clear?
7. When have you watched the office staff or other service workers in A.A. carry a load nobody else would carry?
8. When did somebody confuse paid service with professionalism in your hearing, and what did you think?
9. When have you been tempted to use your A.A. identity to advance a paid opportunity?
10. What is one piece of work in A.A. you have done as a volunteer that you would never want paid?
11. What is one piece of work in A.A. you have watched somebody do that almost certainly needed to be paid?
12. When have you seen the broken anonymity Bill describes, where a member uses A.A. to publicize an outside job?
13. What did the spirit of A.A. feel like before you understood the line between paid service and the Twelfth Step?
14. What did it feel like after?
15. When did you first realize that giving the message away is what keeps it alive in you?

Where We Stand

Fifteen questions on what the work has built.

1. What does nonprofessional A.A. look like in your group today?
2. What does the work of a paid service worker look like in your area, district, or central office?
3. How does your group support those service workers practically?
4. How does your group support them in attitude?
5. Where in your group life are members tempted to mix paid work with carrying the message?
6. How do you tell the difference today between A.A. work and recovery-industry work?
7. What does it look like in your life when you do Twelfth Step work for free with no expectation of return?
8. What does it look like when ego or money sneaks in even a little?
9. How do you handle a newcomer who wants to pay you back for help you gave them?
10. How does your group hold the line on anonymity when members take outside jobs in the alcohol field?
11. Where have you watched a member do that well?
12. Where have you watched it go sideways?
13. What does it mean to you today that the Twelfth Step itself cannot be sold?
14. What does it mean to you today that the laborer is worthy of his hire?
15. Where is Tradition Eight doing its work in you right now?

Where We're Going

Fifteen questions on what is becoming possible.

1. What does deeper practice of Tradition Eight look like for your group going forward?
2. What service work in A.A. is your group asking somebody to carry alone that ought to be shared or paid for?
3. What is one way your group can better honor its paid service workers?
4. Where in your own service work is the line between freely given and quietly compensated getting blurry?
5. Where in your life outside A.A. is your A.A. identity being used in ways it should not be?
6. What is one piece of paid work in the alcohol field you are considering, and how can you keep your anonymity around it?
7. What does it look like to live as someone whose Twelfth Step is given freely and whose other work is honest paid labor?

8. Where in your life is the money motive starting to compromise something that ought to be freely given?
9. Where in your life is fear of being called a professional keeping you from accepting honest service work that needs doing?
10. Who in your life might be on the edge of their own Tradition Eight question?
11. What does it mean to you to keep the Twelfth Step unbought?
12. What does it mean to you to honor the workers who make the Twelfth Step possible?
13. What is one way you can carry the spirit of “freely ye have received, freely give” into a relationship outside A.A.?
14. What is one thing you want to carry out of this meeting tonight?
15. What does it mean to you to keep this line clear for the rest of your life?

Closing Line

We came in being given something we could not pay for. We stay because we have learned how to give it the same way.

Cross-Reference

Members studying Step Eight alongside this Tradition may notice a shared theme: the work of making things right cannot be bought or sold, and yet it is the most valuable work there is.

Tradition Nine

“A.A., as such, ought never be organized; but we may create service boards or committees directly responsible to those they serve.”

Anchor Phrase

Great suffering and great love are A.A.'s disciplinarians; we need no others.

Alternatives, in case this one does not fit:

The difference between the spirit of vested authority and the spirit of service, two concepts which are sometimes poles apart.

A society without organization, animated only by the spirit of service, a true fellowship.

Of course, you are at perfect liberty to handle this matter any way you please. But the majority experience in A.A. does seem to suggest.

Background

Bill Wilson wrote Tradition Nine in 1953 to address a question every newcomer and outside observer eventually asks. How does A.A. work without anyone in charge? The 1946 long form of Tradition Nine said that each A.A. group “needs the least possible organization.” The short form, in use by the early 1950s, sharpened the language: “A.A., as such, ought never be organized.” The 1953 essay opens with the strongest version yet: A.A., as a whole, should never be organized at all. The chapter records the practical discovery that no committee, board, or General Service Conference can give an A.A. member an enforceable order. Bill writes that the moment such an order is issued, the response is either silent disobedience or open laughter. The chapter then introduces one of Bill's most important distinctions: the difference between the spirit of vested authority, which most institutions in the world run on, and the spirit of service, which A.A. runs on. The sentence “Of course, you are at perfect liberty to handle this matter any way you please. But the majority experience in A.A. does seem to suggest...” was coined at the New York office and went into roughly half the letters the office wrote. It is one of the most precise sentences in A.A. literature, and Bill includes it in the chapter because it captures the entire flavor of A.A. governance in a single line.

Setting the Stage

Bill Wilson opens Tradition Nine with what looks like a contradiction. A.A. as a whole, he writes, should never be organized at all. Then, in seeming contradiction, the Fellowship turns around and creates service boards and committees that are themselves organized. How can an

unorganized movement build a service organization for itself? People look at this and ask, what do they mean, no organization?

Bill answers by stepping back. Every nation, every church, every political party, every benevolent association has membership rules. Every society has the authority to discipline its members, enforce obedience, and punish or expel offenders. Every form of human society on earth is, at bottom, a government. Power to direct or govern is the essence of organization everywhere.

Then Bill states the exception. Alcoholics Anonymous does not work that way. Neither the General Service Conference, nor the Foundation Board, nor the humblest group committee can issue a single directive to an A.A. member and make it stick. The Fellowship has tried, plenty of times. Utter failure is always the result. Groups have tried to expel members and watched the banished come back and sit down in the meeting saying this is life for us, you cannot keep us out. Committees have told members to stop sponsoring a chronic slipper and gotten the answer, how I do my Twelfth Step work is my business, who are you to judge. The most resented figure in any meeting, Bill writes, is the old timer full of wisdom who moves to a new town and tries to tell that group how to run its business. He meets either stubborn resistance or, worse, laughter.

Even A.A. headquarters works this way. Trustees and staff can only make suggestions, and very mild ones. Bill quotes the sentence the office wrote into half its letters: of course, you are at perfect liberty to handle this matter any way you please, but the majority experience in A.A. does seem to suggest. That, Bill writes, is a long way from central government. Alcoholics, he writes, cannot be dictated to, individually or collectively.

Bill names what the outside observer misses. The churchman cries that A.A. is making disobedience a virtue. The psychiatrist calls A.A. members defiant brats who will not conform to social usage. The man in the street says they must be nuts. But all three have overlooked the thing that makes A.A. work. The A.A. member who does not follow the suggested Twelve Steps almost certainly signs his own death warrant. His drunkenness and his ruin are not penalties handed down by some authority. They are the natural result of his disobedience to spiritual principles. The same stern threat applies to the group. Unless there is approximate conformity to the Twelve Traditions, the group itself can deteriorate and die. So A.A. members obey spiritual principles, first because they must, and ultimately because they come to love the life such obedience brings. Great suffering and great love, Bill writes, are A.A.'s disciplinarians. The Fellowship needs no others.

The chapter closes by drawing the line that makes service possible without governance. A.A. ought never to name boards to govern it, but it will always need to authorize workers to serve it. The difference is the spirit of vested authority versus the spirit of service. The two are sometimes poles apart. The group committee, the intergroup association, the General Service Conference, the trustees of the Foundation: these are all elected in the spirit of service. The aim of each A.A. member is personal sobriety. The aim of A.A.'s services is to bring that sobriety

within reach of everyone who wants it. If nobody does the chores, if the phone rings unanswered, if the mail goes unopened, the Fellowship as we know it stops. The communication lines to the next sufferer go dark. Tradition Nine looks at first like a chapter about a practical question, Bill writes, but in actual operation it reveals a society without organization, animated only by the spirit of service. A true fellowship.

Where We Begin

Seven questions to set the room before reading.

1. When you hear the phrase “no organization,” what is the first thing that comes to mind?
2. What does the spirit of service mean to you?
3. What is the difference between vested authority and the spirit of service?
4. When have you watched a group function well without anyone in charge?
5. When have you watched an institution try to enforce obedience and lose its soul in the process?
6. What does it mean for suffering and love to be the only disciplinarians?
7. What did you expect this Tradition would say before you read it?

Where We've Been

Fifteen questions on lived experience.

1. What did you assume about who was in charge of A.A. when you first walked in?
2. When did you first discover that nobody could actually tell anyone else what to do?
3. What was your reaction to that discovery?
4. When have you watched a group try to expel a member, and what happened?
5. When have you watched a committee tell a member how to do Twelfth Step work, and how did that land?
6. When have you watched an old timer try to remake a group in the image of another group?
7. When have you been that old timer in some form?
8. When have you taken a suggestion in A.A. that you would have refused as an order?
9. When have you watched somebody slowly come into line with A.A. principles, not because they were told to, but because suffering and love did the work?
10. What did the suffering side of A.A.'s discipline look like in your story?
11. What did the love side of A.A.'s discipline look like in your story?

12. When did you first notice the difference between the spirit of vested authority and the spirit of service?
13. When did you first do an A.A. chore that nobody asked you to do?
14. When have you elected a trusted servant who turned out to be exactly that?
15. When have you watched an elected servant try to govern instead, and what did your group do?

Where We Stand

Fifteen questions on what the work has built.

1. What does the spirit of service look like in your home group today?
2. Where in your group life is somebody quietly authorized to serve, and how do you support them?
3. Where in your group life is somebody trying to govern, and how do you address that?
4. How does your group make decisions without putting anyone in charge?
5. What does “of perfect liberty to handle this matter any way you please” look like in your group’s actual practice?
6. How does your group keep approximate conformity to the Twelve Traditions without enforcement?
7. What does it look like when great suffering does its work in a member of your group?
8. What does it look like when great love does its work in a member of your group?
9. Where in your group is somebody currently on the edge of disobedience to spiritual principles, and what is the group’s response?
10. What is one chore in your group that is essential but unglamorous, and who is doing it?
11. What is one service position in your area or district that you have personal knowledge of, and what does it teach you about the spirit of service?
12. How does your group treat its trusted servants when they are still in office?
13. How does your group treat them when their term ends?
14. What does “directly responsible to those they serve” look like in practice in your group?
15. Where is Tradition Nine doing its work in you right now?

Where We're Going

Fifteen questions on what is becoming possible.

1. What does deeper practice of Tradition Nine look like for your group going forward?
2. What is one piece of service work you are ready to take on in the next year?

3. Where in your group life is the spirit of service asking to replace the spirit of authority?
4. What is one chore that needs doing that no one is currently doing?
5. Where in your life outside A.A. is Tradition Nine asking you to lead by serving rather than by directing?
6. What would it look like to bring this principle into your family?
7. What would it look like to bring it into your workplace?
8. Where in your life are you tempted to govern people who would respond better to suggestion?
9. Where in your life are you tempted to resist suggestion that you would accept from someone whose spirit was right?
10. What is one piece of vested authority you are ready to lay down?
11. What is one piece of service work you are ready to authorize someone else to do without overseeing them?
12. What does it look like to live as someone whose discipline comes from suffering and love rather than from external authority?
13. Who in your life might be on the edge of their own Tradition Nine moment?
14. What is one thing you want to carry out of this meeting tonight?
15. What does it mean to you to keep serving rather than governing for the rest of your life?

Closing Line

We came in expecting to be told what to do. We stay because we have learned how to serve.

Cross-Reference

Members studying Step Nine alongside this Tradition may notice a shared theme: real responsibility is carried, not enforced, and the people who carry it best are the ones who have stopped trying to control others.

Tradition Ten

“Alcoholics Anonymous has no opinion on outside issues; hence the A.A. name ought never be drawn into public controversy.”

Anchor Phrase

So long as we don't argue these matters privately, it's a cinch we never shall publicly.

Alternatives, in case this one does not fit:

This reluctance to fight one another or anybody else is not counted as some special virtue which makes us feel superior to other people.

Since recovery from alcoholism is life itself to us, it is imperative that we preserve in full strength our means of survival.

Had they been left to themselves, and had they stuck to their one goal, they might have found the rest of the answer.

Background

Bill Wilson wrote Tradition Ten in 1953 as the chapter where A.A.'s most cautionary historical example takes center stage. The Washingtonian Society was a movement of alcoholics that began in Baltimore in April 1840 when six drinking buddies challenged each other to give up alcohol entirely and start helping other drinkers do the same. The movement grew explosively. Within a few years it had over a hundred thousand members and chapters in nearly every state. Bill writes in this chapter that the Washingtonians, left to themselves and focused on their one purpose, might have found the rest of the answer almost a century before A.A. did. But the Washingtonians let politicians and reformers, both alcoholic and non-alcoholic, use the society for their own purposes. Members took public positions on the abolition of slavery, then on temperance legislation, then on whatever cause the loudest speaker wished to advance. By the late 1840s the movement had largely collapsed as an effective help for drunks. By the early 1850s it was essentially gone. Bill placed this history at the center of Tradition Ten because the early A.A. members had studied it closely, and the lesson shaped the Tenth Tradition more than any abstract principle could.

Setting the Stage

Bill Wilson opens Tradition Ten with a striking observation. A.A. has never, since it began, been divided by a major controversial issue. It has never publicly taken sides on any question in an embattled world. This, Bill says, is not an earned virtue. The Fellowship was almost born with it.

An old timer captured the principle in one sentence Bill quotes early in the chapter: so long as we don't argue these matters privately, it's a cinch we never shall publicly.

A.A. members, Bill writes, have known by deep instinct from the beginning that the Fellowship must never publicly take sides in any fight, even a worthy one. He sets this conviction against a wide historical backdrop. All of history offers the spectacle of nations and movements torn apart because they were either built for controversy or tempted into it. Others fell apart through sheer self-righteousness as they tried to impose their preferred future on everybody else. Bill names the postwar moment plainly. Millions had recently died in political and economic wars often spurred by religious and racial difference. The possibility of another holocaust hung over every conversation about how the world's resources would be divided. That, Bill writes, is the spiritual climate in which A.A. was born and, by God's grace, has nevertheless flourished.

Bill is careful with what the Tradition does and does not say. The Fellowship's reluctance to fight one another or anybody else is not a special virtue that makes A.A. members feel superior. Nor does Tradition Ten mean that individual A.A. members, restored as citizens of the world, are supposed to back away from their own responsibilities. Members can and should act on their conscience as citizens. But A.A. as a whole, as an institution, is a different matter. The Society does not enter public controversy because it knows it would die if it did. Recovery from alcoholism is life itself to A.A. members. The survival and spread of the Fellowship matters more than the weight A.A. could throw behind any other cause.

This is not because A.A. members are peaceable. Bill is honest. Human beings squabble, and before A.A. leveled off a bit, the Fellowship looked like one prodigious squabble. A corporation director who had just authorized a hundred-thousand-dollar company expenditure would show up at an A.A. business meeting and blow his top over twenty-five dollars in postage stamps. Half a group would storm off to start a new group because they did not like how the first one was being run. Elders turned momentarily Pharisee and sulked. Bitter attacks were launched at members suspected of mixed motives. These puny rows, Bill writes, never did A.A. a particle of harm. They were almost always about how to make A.A. more effective. They were the business of learning to work and live together. They never touched outside issues, and they never reached the public.

Bill closes the chapter with the Washingtonian story. The Washingtonian Society, started in Baltimore a century before A.A., was almost the same idea. Alcoholics helping alcoholics. The early members foresaw the importance of a single aim. Membership reached over a hundred thousand. Left alone, Bill writes, they might have found the rest of the answer. Instead the Washingtonians let politicians and reformers, alcoholic and non-alcoholic alike, use the society for their own purposes. Speakers took violent public positions on the abolition of slavery. Then on temperance reform. The society might have survived the abolition controversy. Bill writes that it did not have a chance from the moment it decided to reform America's drinking habits. When the Washingtonians became temperance crusaders, they lost their effectiveness in helping

alcoholics within a very few years. Early A.A. members studied the wreck and resolved to keep their own Society out of public controversy. That, Bill writes, is the cornerstone of Tradition Ten.

Where We Begin

Seven questions to set the room before reading.

1. When you hear the phrase outside issues, what is the first thing that comes to mind?
2. What does it mean for a group to have no opinion as a group, even when its individual members have many?
3. When have you watched a good organization get pulled into a controversy that destroyed its primary purpose?
4. What does the difference look like between speaking as a citizen and speaking for a group?
5. What does it mean to argue something privately and not publicly?
6. When have you watched a private argument leak into public view, and what happened?
7. What did you expect this Tradition would say before you read it?

Where We've Been

Fifteen questions on lived experience.

1. What did you assume A.A. would have opinions about when you first walked in?
2. What surprised you about the kinds of conversations that did not happen in your first meetings?
3. When did you first notice the absence of political, religious, or reform argument in your home group?
4. When you first heard the line “no opinion on outside issues,” what did you make of it?
5. When have you been tempted to bring an outside issue into a meeting, and what stopped you?
6. When have you watched another member do that, and how did the group respond?
7. When have you watched a small intra-A.A. squabble about how to run a group?
8. Looking back, what was the squabble actually about?
9. When have you been the corporation director Bill describes, blowing up over twenty-five dollars in postage stamps?
10. When have you been the elder turned momentarily Pharisee?
11. What did your sponsor or a trusted member teach you about keeping outside opinions outside?

12. When have you watched a member break this Tradition in some public form, and what was the cost?
13. When did you first hear the Washingtonian story, and what landed for you?
14. What is one cause you personally care deeply about that you have learned to keep separate from A.A.?
15. When did you first realize that A.A. has survived precisely because it has refused to fight?

Where We Stand

Fifteen questions on what the work has built.

1. What does no opinion on outside issues look like in your home group today?
2. Where in your group life is the line between citizen and member being respected?
3. Where in your group life is the line getting blurry?
4. What does it look like in your group when somebody starts to drag an outside issue in?
5. How does your group redirect, gently, when that happens?
6. How do you, personally, hold this Tradition when an outside issue touches something you care about?
7. What does it mean to you today that A.A. as a whole survives by refusing to fight?
8. Where in your group's internal life is squabbling currently happening, and is it about how to make A.A. more effective or about something else?
9. What does a healthy intra-A.A. argument look like in your experience?
10. What does an unhealthy one look like?
11. How does your home group keep its conflicts inside the family rather than letting them become public spectacle?
12. Where in your life have you watched a member act fully as a citizen on an outside issue while keeping A.A. itself out of it?
13. What does the Washingtonian story teach you about the cost of mission drift?
14. Where in your group's recent past has Tradition Ten saved you from an avoidable wreck?
15. Where is Tradition Ten doing its work in you right now?

Where We're Going

Fifteen questions on what is becoming possible.

1. What does deeper practice of Tradition Ten look like for your group going forward?

2. What is one outside issue that has been creeping toward the meeting room, and what is your group's plan for it?
3. What is one private squabble in your group that is asking to be addressed before it grows?
4. Where in your life outside A.A. are you ready to act fully as a citizen on a cause you care about?
5. Where in your life outside A.A. are you tempted to invoke your A.A. identity in ways Tradition Ten asks you to set aside?
6. What is one place in your life where the principle "so long as we don't argue these matters privately, it's a cinch we never shall publicly" would change how you operate?
7. What would it look like to bring this principle into your family?
8. What would it look like to bring it into your workplace?
9. Where in your life are you behaving like a Washingtonian, attaching your sobriety to a crusade that is starting to crowd out your primary purpose?
10. What is one cause you are involved with that you can keep loving without dragging A.A. into it?
11. What does it look like to live as someone whose convictions are strong and whose A.A. membership is kept clear of them publicly?
12. Who in your life might be on the edge of their own Tradition Ten moment?
13. What is one piece of public commentary you are ready to refrain from making in the name of A.A.?
14. What is one thing you want to carry out of this meeting tonight?
15. What does it mean to you to keep A.A. out of public controversy for the rest of your life?

Closing Line

We came in with strong opinions. We stay because we have learned what to keep out of the room.

Cross-Reference

Members studying Step Ten alongside this Tradition may notice a shared theme: a quiet, honest inventory of our own house keeps us out of fights that would otherwise destroy us.

Tradition Eleven

“Our public relations policy is based on attraction rather than promotion; we need always maintain personal anonymity at the level of press, radio, and films.”

Anchor Phrase

This Tradition is a constant and practical reminder that personal ambition has no place in A.A.

Alternatives, in case this one does not fit:

By temperament, nearly every one of us had been an irrepressible promoter, and the prospect of a society composed almost entirely of promoters was frightening.

Here was something rare in the world: a society which said it wished to publicize its principles and its work, but not its individual members.

In it, each member becomes an active guardian of our Fellowship.

Background

Bill Wilson wrote Tradition Eleven in 1953 as the chapter that traces A.A.'s most consequential public-relations decision. By the early 1940s, three major publicity events had shaped A.A.'s growth: a 1939 series in the Cleveland Plain Dealer that took Cleveland membership from a handful to several hundred almost overnight, the 1940 dinner that John D. Rockefeller, Jr. hosted for A.A. in New York which doubled membership inside a year, and Jack Alexander's Saturday Evening Post profile in March 1941 which turned A.A. into a national institution. At one point about a hundred members were breaking anonymity at the public level, arguing that anonymity was horse-and-buggy stuff and that named members of local, national, or international fame could help A.A. grow faster by going public. Bill writes that the press itself was the corrective. Newsmen, editors, and rewrite men had grown to admire A.A.'s anonymity policy more than some of its own members did. They began deleting names and pictures, reminding ambitious members of the policy, and sacrificing good stories to honor it. The principle of attraction rather than promotion was hammered out between A.A. and the press together over more than a decade.

Setting the Stage

Bill Wilson opens Tradition Eleven with gratitude. Without its legions of well-wishers, he writes, A.A. could never have grown the way it has. Newspaper pieces, radio programs, motion pictures, and eventually television have brought half the membership into the rooms. The inquiring voices on the telephone are not all alcoholics or their families. Doctors read medical

journals about A.A. and call for more information. Clergymen see articles in their church publications and reach out. Employers learn that great corporations have endorsed the program and want to know what can be done about alcoholism in their own firms. The Fellowship has had to develop the best possible public relations policy. Bill writes that after many painful experiences, A.A. arrived at one that is the opposite, in many ways, of standard practice. The Fellowship relies on attraction rather than promotion.

Bill spells out the contrast. A political party wants to win an election, so it advertises the virtues of its leaders. A worthy charity wants to raise money, so it puts every distinguished name it can get onto its letterhead. Much of the political, economic, and religious life of the world depends on publicized leadership. People who symbolize a cause fill a real human need. Bill does not dispute that. But being in the public eye, he writes, is hazardous, especially for A.A. By temperament, nearly every alcoholic had been an irrepressible promoter. The prospect of a society made entirely of promoters was frightening. So the Fellowship had to exercise self-restraint.

The result, Bill writes, was startling. Restraint produced more favorable publicity than any team of press agents could have generated. A.A. needed publicity. The solution turned out to be letting the Fellowship's friends do the publicizing. Veteran newsmen, trained doubters by profession, went all out to carry the message. To them, A.A. was something more than a source of good copy. On almost every news front, journalists attached themselves to A.A. as friends.

Bill describes how the press first reacted to the anonymity policy. They were genuinely puzzled. Here was a society that wanted to publicize its principles and work but not its individual members. Then they got it. The press was delighted. From that point forward, journalists reported on A.A. with an enthusiasm even ardent members would find hard to match. Bill notes that there was a time when the press of America thought A.A.'s anonymity was better for A.A. than some of A.A.'s own members did. About a hundred members were breaking anonymity at the public level, arguing the principle was outdated and that named members of local or national fame could speed the Fellowship's growth. Their friends in the writing profession disagreed. The Foundation wrote letters to nearly every news outlet in North America explaining the principle of attraction over promotion. Editors and rewrite men began deleting names and pictures from A.A. copy. They reminded ambitious members of the policy. They sacrificed good stories to keep the principle intact. Today, Bill writes, only a few A.A. members deliberately break anonymity at the public level.

Bill closes the chapter by stating what Tradition Eleven means below the surface. It is more than sound public relations. It is more than a refusal of self-seeking. The Tradition is a constant practical reminder that personal ambition has no place in A.A. Under it, every member becomes an active guardian of the Fellowship.

Where We Begin

Seven questions to set the room before reading.

1. When you hear the phrase attraction rather than promotion, what is the first thing that comes to mind?
2. What is the difference between drawing people to something and pushing them toward it?
3. When have you been promoted at by somebody and pulled away from what they were selling?
4. When have you been attracted to something because of the quality of the people around it?
5. What does it mean to maintain personal anonymity at the public level?
6. What does it mean for ambition to have no place somewhere?
7. What did you expect this Tradition would say before you read it?

Where We've Been

Fifteen questions on lived experience.

1. How did you first hear about A.A.?
2. What was attractive about the people in your first meeting?
3. What did you notice about how A.A. members spoke about A.A. in public, if you noticed anything at all in those early days?
4. What did you think about anonymity when you first heard it explained?
5. Were you ever tempted to break your anonymity early in sobriety, and what stopped you?
6. When have you watched an A.A. show-off, in Bill's phrase, try to put themselves before microphones or cameras?
7. When have you watched somebody quietly tell a friend, a doctor, or an employer about A.A. in a way that helped?
8. What did the difference between those two feel like?
9. When have you watched a member break anonymity at the public level, and what was the cost?
10. When did you first see the irrepressible promoter in yourself, in or out of A.A.?
11. What did your sponsor or a trusted member teach you about being a guardian of the Fellowship?
12. When did you first appreciate what the press has done for A.A. by honoring this Tradition?

13. When have you watched an A.A. story go through journalism done well, with names and pictures left out?
14. What does it mean to you that personal ambition almost destroyed A.A. before this Tradition was settled?
15. When did you first realize that you yourself were a piece of A.A.'s public face, anonymous or not?

Where We Stand

Fifteen questions on what the work has built.

1. What does attraction rather than promotion look like in your home group today?
2. Where in your group life is the quiet, attractive quality of recovery most visible?
3. Where in your group life is there a promoter spirit creeping in?
4. How does your group handle requests from outside organizations to speak about A.A. in public?
5. How does your group instruct speakers, reporters, or photographers about anonymity at the public level?
6. What does your own use of social media look like in relation to this Tradition?
7. What does the distinction look like in your life between telling a friend you are in A.A. and announcing it to the public?
8. How do you tell, today, the difference between sharing your story for service and sharing it for attention?
9. When has the promoter inside you wanted to step up to a microphone, and how have you handled it?
10. Where in your life are you currently functioning as an active guardian of the Fellowship?
11. Who in your group most clearly embodies attraction rather than promotion, and what have you learned from them?
12. How does your group support its members who become locally or nationally known in other fields?
13. How does your group hold the line on anonymity when those members are tempted to use their fame for A.A.?
14. What does it mean to you today that personal ambition has no place in A.A.?
15. Where is Tradition Eleven doing its work in you right now?

Where We're Going

Fifteen questions on what is becoming possible.

1. What does deeper practice of Tradition Eleven look like for your group going forward?
2. What is one place in your public life where you are ready to firm up your anonymity?
3. What is one quiet, private conversation about A.A. you are ready to have with someone in your life?
4. Where in your life is the irrepressible promoter still trying to step out from behind the principle?
5. What does it look like to live as someone whose recovery is visible by attraction without ever being announced?
6. Where in your life outside A.A. is Tradition Eleven asking you to let your work speak for itself?
7. What would it look like to bring this principle into your family?
8. What would it look like to bring it into your workplace?
9. What is one place where your name is currently attached to your A.A. membership in public that needs to come unattached?
10. What is one piece of personal distinction inside A.A. that you are ready to lay down?
11. Who in your life might be on the edge of their own Tradition Eleven moment?
12. What does it mean to you to become an active guardian of the Fellowship?
13. What would it look like to leave the press, the radio, the films, and the social platforms to handle A.A. without you in front of any camera?
14. What is one thing you want to carry out of this meeting tonight?
15. What does it mean to you to keep your anonymity at the public level for the rest of your life?

Closing Line

We came in wanting to be noticed. We stay because we have learned what the quiet of attraction can do.

Cross-Reference

Members studying Step Eleven alongside this Tradition may notice a shared theme: the deeper work is done in quiet, and the fruit of it is unmistakable to anyone watching.

Tradition Twelve

“Anonymity is the spiritual foundation of all our Traditions, ever reminding us to place principles before personalities.”

Anchor Phrase

Anonymity is real humility at work.

Alternatives, in case this one does not fit:

The spiritual substance of anonymity is sacrifice.

Humility, expressed by anonymity, is the greatest safeguard that Alcoholics Anonymous can ever have.

Each of us takes part in the weaving of a protective mantle which covers our whole Society and under which we may grow and work in unity.

Background

Bill Wilson wrote Tradition Twelve in 1953 as the chapter that names what holds the other eleven Traditions together. The word anonymity meant something different to the earliest A.A. members than it means today. In the late 1930s, A.A. groups were small, secret societies. New prospects could only find them through a few trusted friends. The bare hint of publicity, even for the work itself, alarmed the founders. By the time the Big Book was published in 1939, the foreword admitted that anonymity was partly a practical defense against being overrun, and partly the lingering fear of professional people who did not want to be exposed as alcoholics. Over the next decade, A.A. grew from a few hundred members to tens of thousands, and the meaning of anonymity matured with it. The chapter records that evolution. By 1953 Bill could write that anonymity had become the spiritual foundation of every other Tradition, not because of fear but because of sacrifice. The earlier Traditions had asked members to give up money, prestige, ambition, opinion, organization, and public recognition. Tradition Twelve names the underlying disposition all of those sacrifices require: humility willing to place principles before personalities.

Setting the Stage

Bill Wilson opens Tradition Twelve with a single sentence that sets the frame for the entire chapter. The spiritual substance of anonymity, he writes, is sacrifice. Because the Twelve Traditions repeatedly ask members to give up personal desires for the common good, the sacrificial spirit, well symbolized by anonymity, is the foundation of them all. A.A.'s proven

willingness to make these sacrifices, Bill writes, is what gives outsiders their high confidence in the Fellowship's future.

But in the beginning, Bill is honest, anonymity was not born of confidence. It was the child of early fear. The first nameless groups were secret societies. New prospects could find A.A. only through a few trusted friends. The bare hint of publicity, even for the work, shocked the early members. Though they were no longer drinking, they still believed they had to hide from public distrust and contempt. When the Big Book appeared in 1939, its foreword admitted the fear directly: members were too few to handle a flood of personal appeals, and as business and professional people, they could not carry on their work if their names became publicly attached to alcoholism.

As A.A. grew, Bill writes, anonymity problems grew with it. Members would get excited about the recovery of a fellow alcoholic and start talking, even in good faith, about the intimate and harrowing details of his case that had been meant for the sponsor's ear alone. The aggrieved member would say, rightly, that his trust had been broken. When such stories leaked outside A.A., the loss of confidence was severe. People stopped coming. The first practical lesson of anonymity emerged: every member's name and story belonged to that member, to be shared or kept private as the member wished.

At the same time, with characteristic intemperance, some newcomers did not care about secrecy at all. Barely dry, they rushed about buttonholing anyone who would listen, placed themselves in front of microphones and cameras, and sometimes got distressingly drunk and let their groups down with a bang. They had changed from A.A. members into A.A. show-offs.

The contrast made the question unavoidable. How anonymous should an A.A. member be? A.A. could not be a secret society. It also could not be a vaudeville circuit. Charting the path between those extremes took a long time. The pattern that emerged was this. A newcomer naturally tells his family and the people who tried to help him: his doctor, his minister, his closest friends. As he gains confidence he tells his employer and business associates. He learns to talk easily about A.A. in private conversations, and many new members come in because of those quiet disclosures. This was not in the strict letter of anonymity, Bill writes, but was well within its spirit. As open meetings grew and outside speakers became common, anonymity was preserved by keeping names and pictures out of any press coverage.

Then came the three publicity events that changed everything: the Cleveland Plain Dealer series, the Rockefeller dinner, and Jack Alexander's Saturday Evening Post profile. Each one multiplied A.A.'s size. Each one brought more requests for newspaper, magazine, film, radio, and television appearances. Bill writes that the Fellowship realized this tide could do incalculable good or great harm depending entirely on how it was channeled. The risk was clear. A.A. could not afford to let self-appointed members present themselves as messiahs before the whole public. The promoter instinct in every alcoholic, if it got loose at that altitude, could undo the Fellowship. One publicly named member getting drunk or using the A.A. name

for his own purposes could do permanent damage. At the level of press, radio, films, and television, the only possible answer was one hundred percent anonymity. There, without exception, principles had to come before personalities.

Bill closes the chapter with the underlying claim. These experiences taught A.A. that anonymity is real humility at work. It is an all-pervading spiritual quality that today keynotes A.A. life everywhere. Moved by the spirit of anonymity, members try to give up natural desires for personal distinction both among fellow alcoholics and before the general public. As those human aspirations are laid aside, Bill writes, each member takes part in the weaving of a protective mantle that covers the whole Society and under which the Fellowship may grow and work in unity. Humility, expressed by anonymity, is the greatest safeguard A.A. can ever have.

Where We Begin

Seven questions to set the room before reading.

1. When you hear the word anonymity, what is the first thing that comes to mind?
2. What does it mean to place a principle before a personality?
3. What does sacrifice have to do with anonymity?
4. When have you been the keeper of somebody else's story?
5. When has somebody else been the keeper of yours?
6. What does humility have to do with what name does or does not get spoken?
7. What did you expect this Tradition would say before you read it?

Where We've Been

Fifteen questions on lived experience.

1. What did the word anonymous mean to you when you first walked into A.A.?
2. Whose name did you trust your story to first?
3. What did it cost you to say that name out loud?
4. When have you been the aggrieved member whose private story got told without permission?
5. When have you been the member who told someone else's story when it was not yours to tell?
6. What did your sponsor or a trusted member teach you about confidentiality in the early days?
7. When did you first see the show-off Bill describes, in or out of yourself?
8. Were you ever tempted to use A.A. to draw attention to yourself, and what stopped you?

9. When have you watched a member break anonymity at the public level and watched what followed?
10. When did you first start telling people in your private life about A.A.?
11. Who was the first person outside A.A. you told, and what was the conversation like?
12. What did the quiet disclosures Bill describes do for your fear of the alcoholic stigma?
13. When did you first hear the phrase “principles before personalities” and what did it mean to you then?
14. What did it mean to you when somebody chose principle over personality in a moment where you would have preferred the opposite?
15. When did you first realize that anonymity was about something deeper than secrecy?

Where We Stand

Fifteen questions on what the work has built.

1. What does anonymity look like in your home group today?
2. What does confidentiality look like in your sponsorship today?
3. Where in your life are you holding somebody else's story carefully?
4. Where in your life is somebody else holding yours?
5. What does placing principles before personalities look like in your group when somebody you do not like is right?
6. What does it look like when somebody you do like is wrong?
7. How do you handle it when a member's behavior makes you want to focus on them instead of on the principle?
8. Where in your life are you tempted to use your A.A. identity to draw distinction inside the rooms?
9. Where in your life are you tempted to draw distinction outside the rooms?
10. How does your home group keep anonymity at the public level when the press, the camera, or the social platform comes calling?
11. What does humility look like in you today, in Bill's sense of anonymity as humility at work?
12. What does the protective mantle Bill describes feel like to you in your home group?
13. Where in your group is somebody quietly weaving that mantle right now?
14. Where in your life are you weaving it?
15. Where is Tradition Twelve doing its work in you right now?

Where We're Going

Fifteen questions on what is becoming possible.

1. What does deeper practice of anonymity look like for you going forward?
2. What is one place in your public life where your anonymity needs firming up?
3. What is one place in your private life where you are ready to let your A.A. membership be quietly known?
4. Where in your group life are you ready to place a principle ahead of a personality you have been struggling with?
5. Where in your group life are you ready to place a principle ahead of a personality you have been favoring?
6. What is one piece of personal distinction inside A.A. you are ready to lay down?
7. What does it look like to live as someone whose humility shows up as anonymity rather than as performance?
8. Where in your life outside A.A. is Tradition Twelve asking you to be less visible and more useful?
9. What would it look like to bring this principle into your family?
10. What would it look like to bring it into your workplace?
11. Who in your life might be on the edge of their own Tradition Twelve moment?
12. What is one sacrifice this Tradition is asking of you that you can name and accept?
13. What does it mean to you to take part in weaving the protective mantle that covers the whole Society?
14. What is one thing you want to carry out of this meeting tonight?
15. What does it mean to you to keep anonymity as humility at work for the rest of your life?

Closing Line

We came in chasing distinction. We stay because we have learned what the protective mantle of anonymity can do.

Cross-Reference

Members studying Step Twelve alongside this Tradition may notice a shared theme: the spiritual awakening at the end of the Steps and the humility at the foundation of the Traditions are the same thing, lived out in one alcoholic and lived out among many.

Glossary

Plain-language definitions of terms members may encounter in the 12&12 and in A.A. meetings. These are working definitions in the spirit of A.A. usage, not formal or clinical ones.

Allergy of the body. The physical reaction that follows the alcoholic's first drink. Once an alcoholic starts drinking, the body craves more, and stopping by willpower becomes nearly impossible. Dr. William Silkworth introduced this idea to Bill Wilson in the 1930s, and it appears in the Big Book chapter "The Doctor's Opinion." Paired with the obsession of the mind, it forms the two-edged condition Bill describes in Step One.

Amends. A direct effort to repair damage done to another person. Not the same as an apology. Amends usually require a face-to-face conversation, a change in behavior, restitution where possible, or all three. Covered in Steps Eight and Nine.

Anonymity. The practice of keeping personal identity out of public discussion of A.A. At the meeting and personal level, it means a member's name and story are theirs to share or withhold as they choose. At the public level, including press, radio, films, television, and social media, it means full personal anonymity without exception. Tradition Twelve names anonymity as the spiritual foundation of all the Traditions: principles before personalities.

Big Book. The common name for Alcoholics Anonymous, the foundational text of A.A., first published in 1939 and revised through several editions since.

Bleeding deacon. A.A. slang from Tradition Two for a former leader who cannot let go of his position when the group conscience moves on. The bleeding deacon stays consumed with self-pity, schemes for re-election, and sometimes drinks. Contrast with elder statesman.

Carry the message. The Twelfth Step work of bringing the experience, strength, and hope of recovery to another alcoholic. The phrase comes from the wording of Step Twelve and is one of the most common shorthand expressions in A.A.

Conference. (See General Service Conference.)

Conscious contact. The ongoing, lived relationship with a Higher Power, deepened through prayer and meditation. The phrase comes from Step Eleven.

Defects of character. The persistent personal shortcomings that drive an alcoholic's behavior. Step Four asks the member to identify them. Steps Six and Seven address becoming ready to have them removed and humbly asking for their removal. The 12&12 chapter on Step Four uses the Seven Deadly Sins as a working vocabulary for defects: pride, greed, lust, anger, gluttony, envy, and sloth.

Elder statesman. A.A. slang from Tradition Two for a former leader who has accepted being replaced, holds no resentment, and remains available with experience and quiet counsel when the group asks. The elder statesman is one of A.A.'s true forms of leadership.

Fellowship. The community of A.A. members worldwide, taken as a whole. Capitalized when used in this sense.

Foundation Office, the Foundation. The original name for what became, in 1954, the General Service Office of A.A. in New York. Bill Wilson uses the older name throughout the 12&12 because he wrote the book before the change.

General Service Conference. The annual meeting of delegates representing A.A. groups across the United States and Canada. The Conference advises the General Service Board, which holds the Fellowship's legal and financial responsibilities. Neither has any power to govern individual A.A. members or groups. Tradition Nine.

General Service Office (G.S.O.). The central A.A. service office in New York, which handles correspondence, literature, and worldwide communications for the Fellowship. Formerly called the Foundation Office.

Group conscience. The collective judgment of an A.A. group, arrived at through discussion and prayer, on a matter affecting the group. Tradition Two names group conscience as the way a loving God expresses authority in A.A. A group conscience decision is not a majority vote in the political sense. It is the group's best attempt to discern the right course of action together.

Higher Power. The term A.A. uses for whatever a member understands to be the spiritual source greater than the self. Members are free to understand a Higher Power in their own way. Steps Two, Three, Five, Six, Seven, and Eleven each engage this concept from a different angle.

Home group. The single A.A. group a member identifies as their primary group, where they hold membership, participate in service, and are known by name. Most members have one home group, even when they attend many meetings.

Inventory. A written or spoken examination of one's own behavior, motives, instincts, and defects. Step Four is the searching and fearless moral inventory. Step Ten is the daily inventory practice that turns the work of the earlier Steps into a way of life.

Just for Today. A short A.A. meditation often read at the close of a meeting, beginning "Just for today I will try to live through this day only." Frequently attributed in A.A. literature to a Catholic prayer of the same name; the form used in the Fellowship has been refined over decades.

Lay therapist. A non-credentialed counselor working with alcoholics for pay. In 1938 Bill Wilson was offered such a position at Towns Hospital and his home group told him not to take it.

Tradition Two records the story. The decision shaped A.A.'s permanent refusal of professional Twelfth Step work.

Newcomer. Any A.A. member in early sobriety. There is no formal definition of how long someone is a newcomer. The term is used with care and affection.

Obsession of the mind. The mental compulsion that drives the alcoholic back to drink despite painful consequences. Paired with the allergy of the body, it is one of the two forces Bill names in Step One as too strong for unaided human willpower to overcome.

Open meeting. An A.A. meeting that welcomes non-alcoholic visitors: family members, friends, members of the helping professions, members of the press provided anonymity is honored, or anyone curious about A.A. Contrast with a closed meeting, which is for alcoholics only.

Pink cloud. A.A. slang for the elevated emotional state some newcomers experience in early sobriety. Not a clinical term. Bill warns in Step Twelve, Part 2 that the pink cloud can lead to two-stepping and that life eventually hands every member a lump that two-stepping cannot carry them through.

Pioneer, pioneers. Members of A.A. from the late 1930s and the 1940s, the first decade or so of the Fellowship's existence. Bill Wilson is the most prominent. Dr. Bob Smith, Bill's co-founder, and Sister Ignatia of Akron are others. The pioneers' experience is the foundation on which the Twelve Traditions were built.

Powerless. The condition Bill describes in Step One. The alcoholic cannot, by self-will alone, control the drinking or the consequences. Powerlessness is not weakness. In the 12&12 it is the bedrock on which a sober life can be built.

Promoter, promoter instinct. Bill Wilson's term in the 12&12 for the alcoholic's tendency to push, sell, advertise, and seek attention. Bill writes that by temperament nearly every A.A. member had been an irrepressible promoter, and that the prospect of a society made entirely of promoters was one of the reasons the Traditions had to be hammered out. Tradition Eleven.

Restoration to sanity. The work Step Two describes a Higher Power doing in the life of the alcoholic. Not a single event but an ongoing process.

Rule 62. A short, practical, written reminder originating from the Middleton group story in Tradition Four. After the group's elaborate alcoholic center collapsed, the lead organizer sent a small card to the Foundation office reading "Middleton Group, Rule 62." The card unfolded to one sentence: "Don't take yourself too damn seriously." The phrase has since become A.A. shorthand for the humility needed when a good idea fails.

Self-will. The alcoholic's habitual pattern of trying to run the show alone, on personal preference, without reference to a Higher Power or to other people. Steps Three and Seven

directly address self-will. Step Twelve, Part 3 ties it to the “number one” personality Bill describes in the closing section on ambition.

Serenity Prayer. A brief prayer used widely in A.A.: “God, grant me the serenity to accept the things I cannot change, courage to change the things I can, and wisdom to know the difference.” Bill Wilson introduces it as a Step Three practice in the 12&12.

Service, service work. Any work done to support the functioning of A.A. and the carrying of the message. Includes sponsorship, making coffee, setting up chairs, holding a group position, intergroup work, district work, area work, and General Service Conference work. Distinct from Twelfth Step work in the narrow sense, though Bill writes that all of it is service of the same message.

Slip, slipped, slippee. A.A. slang for a relapse, the person who relapsed, and the act of relapsing. Used without judgment in A.A. usage.

Sobriety, sober. In A.A., not drinking, plus the spiritual and emotional growth that follows. A.A. members generally measure sobriety from the last day of drinking.

Sponsor. An A.A. member who works one-on-one with another member, often a newcomer, to help them work the Steps and live the program. Sponsorship is informal, voluntary, and unpaid. There is no formal training or certification.

St. Francis Prayer (Peace Prayer). The prayer beginning “Lord, make me a channel of thy peace.” Bill Wilson presents it in Step Eleven, Part 1 as a meditation exercise. The prayer first appeared anonymously in a French religious magazine in 1912 and was later attributed to Francis of Assisi.

Step, Steps, the Steps. The Twelve Steps of recovery, the personal program of action in A.A. Each Step has a chapter in the 12&12.

Three Legacies. A phrase used in A.A. for the three founding gifts the pioneers left the Fellowship: Recovery (the Steps), Unity (the Traditions), and Service (the structure of group, district, area, intergroup, and General Service Office).

Tradition, Traditions, the Twelve Traditions. The twelve principles that guide A.A. groups and the Fellowship as a whole. First published in 1946, refined in 1953, and addressed in the second half of the 12&12.

Trusted servant. Tradition Two's name for any A.A. member elected or appointed to a service position. The position carries responsibility but no governing authority. Trusted servants do not govern. They serve.

Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions (the 12&12). The book by Bill Wilson, published in 1953, which is the primary source text for this guide.

Twelfth Step, Twelfth Step work, Twelfth Stepping. The work of carrying the A.A. message to another alcoholic, especially a newcomer or a still-suffering alcoholic. Named for the action half of Step Twelve.

Two-stepping. Bill Wilson's term in Step Twelve, Part 2 for the member who has gotten sober on Steps One and Twelve while neglecting the other ten Steps. Bill writes that two-stepping works during the pink-cloud period but fails when life hands the member a lump that requires the whole program.

Washingtonians, Washingtonian Society. A nineteenth-century American movement of alcoholics helping alcoholics, founded in Baltimore in 1840. The Washingtonians reached over a hundred thousand members and might have found the answer to alcoholism, but were drawn into public controversy over abolition and temperance reform, and collapsed within a few years. Tradition Ten draws directly on their cautionary example.

Working the Steps. The practice of going through the Twelve Steps with a sponsor, usually in order, doing the action each Step calls for. The Steps are typically worked once at the beginning of sobriety and then returned to throughout a member's life.